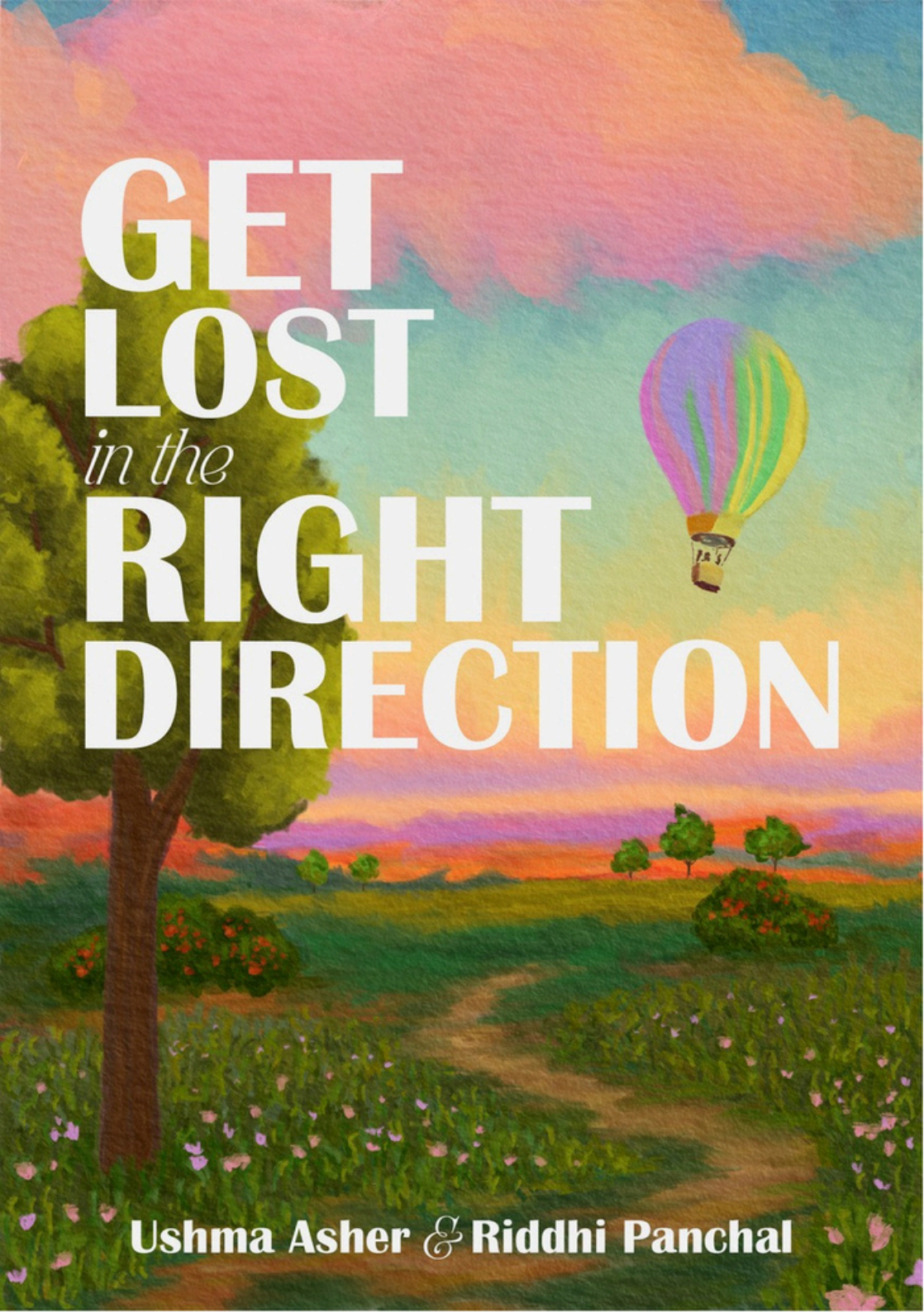




GET LOST *in the* RIGHT DIRECTION

Ushma Asher & Riddhi Panchal

Get lost
in the
Right Direction

Ushma Asher & Riddhi Panchal

Acknowledgement

Welcome to our most special project yet.

We would like to thank everyone who made the project possible.

Himani, for her wonderful illustrations that made the book come to life.

Priyanshi, for editing and making the book what it is.

Nishchay, for his relentless pursuit to refine this journal.

Our fellow therapists, who believed in us every step of the way.

Our friends, who let us disappear while we jumped into the madness of creation; and their unwavering belief in us.

Our family, for always letting us be creative.

Our partners, for putting up with our incessant discussions about the journal.

And most importantly, YOU, the readers. Thank you for healing even when it's tedious.

We hope this journal brings you all the peace you deserve.

*With love,
Riddhi & Ushma*

Prologue

This is not your typical journal!

Life can be really complex. Journaling does not need to be.
Which is why we did our best to make this journal as much YOURS as it's OURS.

Unlike a typical journal, you do not need to go in a chronological order.
If you look at the index, it will direct you to a page that aligns with how you are feeling.

When we started working on the journal, our main goal was to give you a companion- something to take around with you on days when you are feeling too much...or days when you are not sure how to talk to anyone...or even as a means to have deeper connections with the people around you.

The journal is black and white because, like we said before, this book is YOURS!
The purpose of the illustrations is to provide you a partially blank canvas. We encourage you to color every page, every illustration, and every thought into existence.

May this book provide you the much needed respite you deserve.

<i>What do you need?</i>	<i>Topic</i>	<i>Turn to</i>
I need to love myself	Self-care	1
I need to ease my anxiety	Tea with Anxiety	8
I need to feel more creative	Creativity & Inner Child	14
I need a break from digital chaos	Social Media Break	18
I need to feel rested & renewed	Burnout	29
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Self-care

Word from a therapist

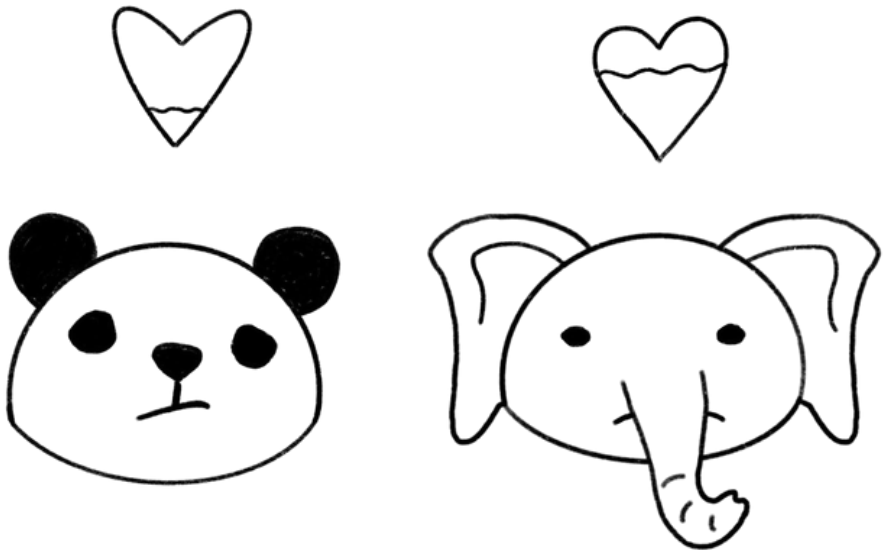
When I tell people I'm a therapist, I often have one of two reactions:

"Can you read my mind?"
&

"How do you listen to people all day?"

When you're in Psychology class, the first thing you're taught is the concept of 'EMPATHY' (which is vastly different from sympathy).

You're taught to learn to walk a mile in someone's shoes. My job is to then return the shoes without carrying them home. Because my job requires me to extend genuine & unceasing empathy, it can sometimes drain me out.



Most of us, even when we love our work, friends, and life, are capable of feeling fatigued. For me, it got to a point where my body forced me to take a pause (something I wasn't allowing myself)

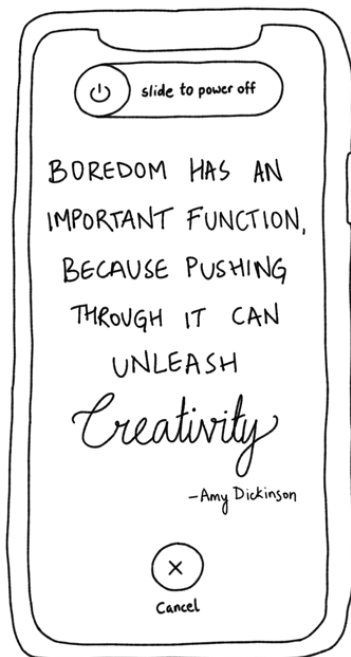
I think the idea of 'self-care' has become greatly commercialized & I've actively avoided participating in it.

Self-care is supposed to be personal, sustainable, & consistent.

Here are my top ways to take care of myself

- Being mindful of who I surround myself with: An overlooked & lackluster part of self-care is honoring yourself. I have let go of friendships & relationships that made me feel drained or negative. Evaluate people closest to you & how you feel after spending time with them.
- Regular therapy: Speaking to a therapist often helps me relieve my stress, feel energized, & put things into perspective.
- Alone time: I love spending time alone. It's my time to uninterruptedly paint, dance, play the guitar, shop, reflect on my future, & simply exist. It makes most people uncomfortable to spend time alone but I urge you to try it out & reconnect with yourself.
- Unplug: It's important to put your phone aside & allow your brain to be 'bored' for some time. Studies have shown that as being important.

Love,
Ushma



Create a comfort playlist

Put your phone away. Listen to your comfort music and do the next activities.



Design your dream self-care day

Imagine a day dedicated entirely to your well-being.
What would it include?



work



health



travel



home



finances

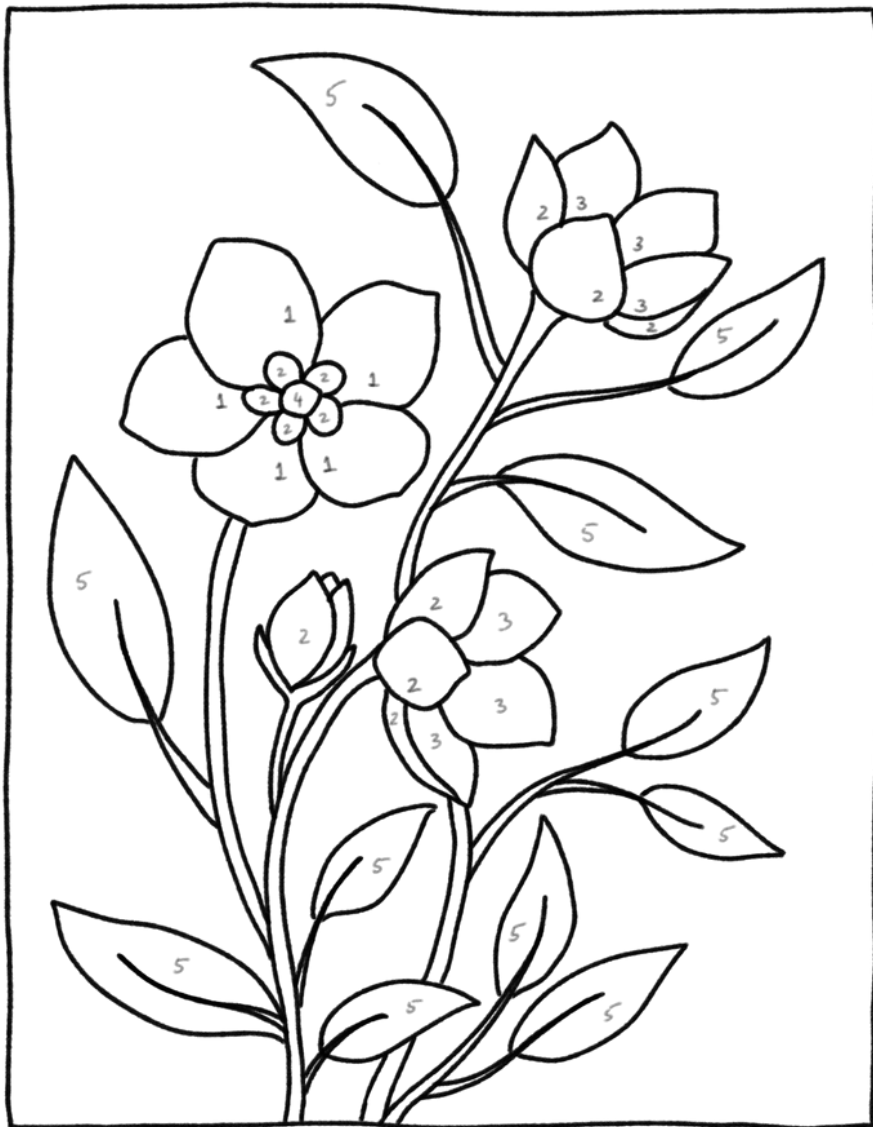


hobbies

Let's de-clutter that mind!

Write down everything that's on your mind.
Cross out the things that you can let go of for now.

Let's put that phone away and give ourselves a break!



Light Pink-1 Pink-2 Dark Pink-3 Yellow-4 Green-5 Dark Green-6

Unleash your inner child

Color your worries away



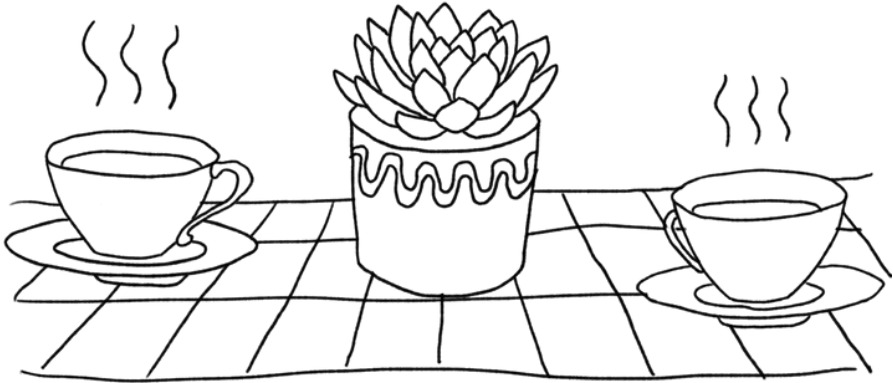
Tea with Anxiety

Word from a therapist

Oh no! An unwanted guest! Dreadful to say the least.

What do you do when that happens?

As much as you don't want them around, you don't shoo them away. You may invite them in, although reluctantly, but you'd do so kindly. You would keep conversations brief and superficial, but you'd invite them in. You would probably not insist they stay back for dinner, but you would invite them in. You would know that while it's an unwelcome presence, they are not here to stay.



Treat your anxiety exactly like that. It's unwelcome and uncomfortable. Invite it in for tea anyway. Ask it what brings it home. Acknowledge its presence and have a conversation. Know that it's no more than an unwelcome guest. It's not here to stay. Have some tea and let it pass. The more you engage, the longer it lingers.

Let it pass!

Most kids cry on their first ever day of school. I wasn't any different. Most kids, however, get used to the new environment once they socialize with other children & teachers. The older I grew, the more I struggled with managing my emotions. I would often have stomach aches from the separation anxiety when my mother would go to work. I was inconsolable.

As an adult, I always called myself a very 'difficult' child until a therapist pointed out that I was simply a child with unmet needs. I didn't know any better. Neither did my parents. Psychology & mental health were foreign concepts in the early 2000s. Because 'anxiety' wasn't a familiar concept, it went untreated throughout my childhood.

Come adolescence- time for a new college, new beginnings, new friends. First day of college- I froze. I felt debilitating anxiety that made me run away from class. This happened repeatedly. I felt so alone in a room full of people, even when I was surrounded by friends who truly cared about me. I couldn't understand what made mundane things so incredibly difficult for me. Fortunately, as an Arts student, I studied Psychology as a subject and for the first time in my life, felt seen & understood. Everything finally made sense. What I had felt all those years was just anxiety. Once I understood that, I started going for therapy.

Going for therapy in my young adulthood was a game changer. I learned so much about my emotions & behaviors. I slowly learned to cope with my anxiety & although it didn't disappear, it definitely wasn't as crippling anymore.

Now in my late 20s, I still experience anxiety from time to time. Sometimes it feels incapacitating. Some of my childhood anxiety that wasn't healed seeps through the corners into my adult life. It affects my feelings towards myself & the people I love. It affects how nervous I feel about finances & the future.

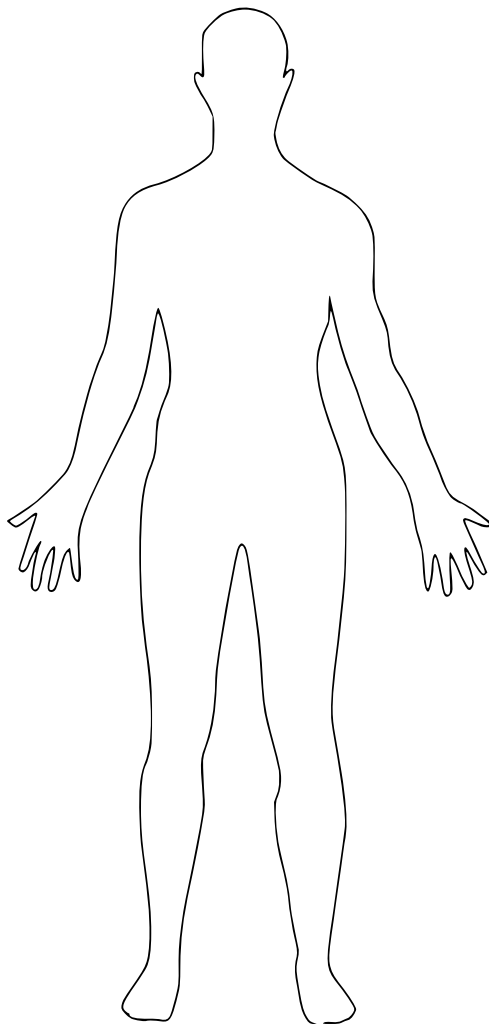
Having said this, I genuinely believe that going to therapy consistently has improved the quality of my life tenfold. To have someone who listens to me non-judgmentally & tracks my progress is truly a gift. I also believe that anxiety is one of those emotions that fights back the harder you resist. So I let it pass. I let myself be anxious until I'm not anxious anymore. Granted, not having anxiety would be like playing life at the easiest level, I have accepted that it's an obstacle I must cross everyday to live the life of my dreams.

*Love,
Ushma*

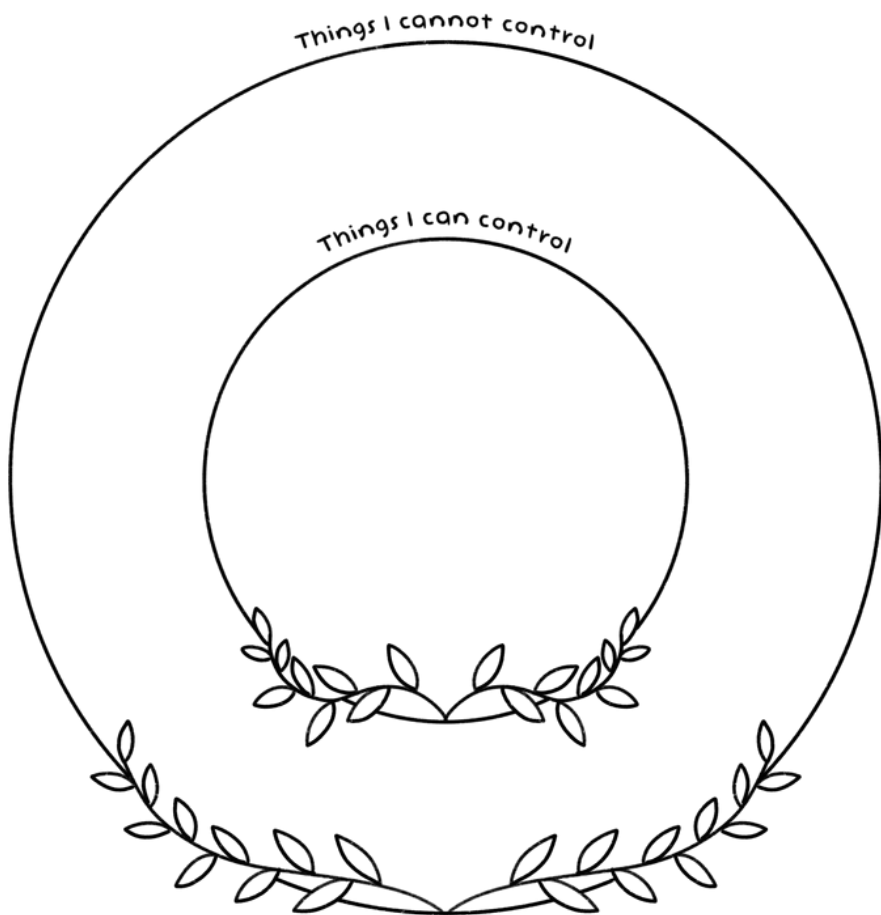
“Where am I feeling this in my body?”

Anxiety can feel physically painful.

So spend a moment with this question & then take a few deep breaths, slowly scan your body, and color where you are feeling it.

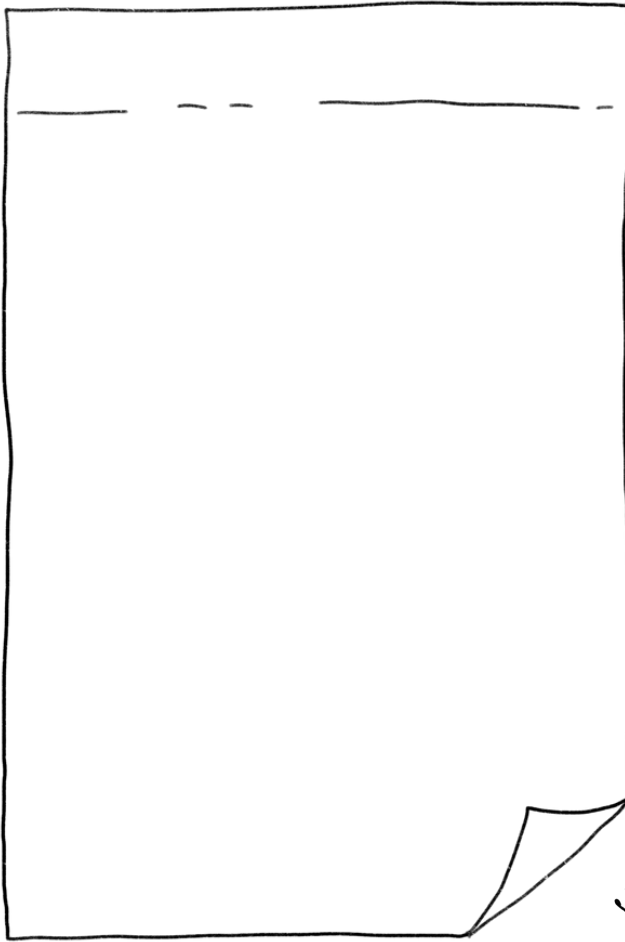


Focus on Circle of Control



Feed me your worries

Write down all your worries here, make them tangible and safely store them here. Come back to them in a year and see how much they matter then.

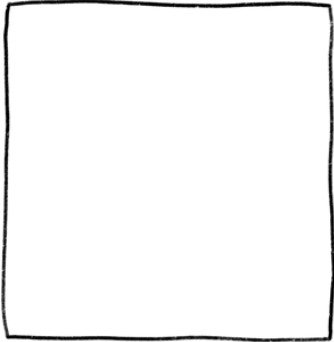


Butterfly hug:

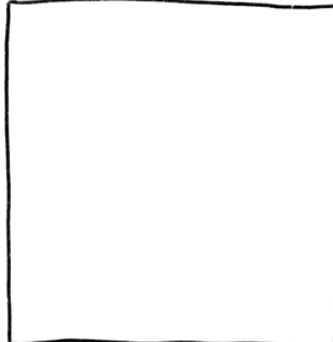
Let's ground ourselves with this activity. Take a few deep breaths, cross your arms over your chest, palms facing down like you're giving yourself a hug. Now, tap one hand at a time as you continue breathing deeply. Do this for 30-40 seconds and you will notice your body starting to relax.

Safe space

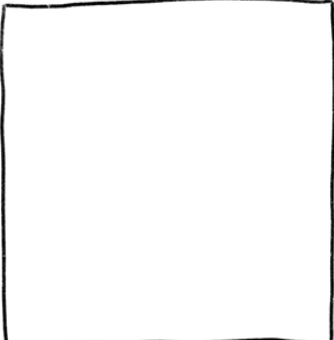
Mention what safety looks like to you.



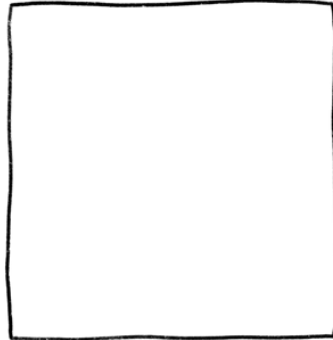
My safe person



My safe object



My safe place



My safe movie

Creativity & Inner Child

Doodle freely for 5 minutes.

Don't worry about making it perfect; just let your hand move and see where it takes you.

Finding yourself....

- What parts of your younger self do you miss?

- What was your biggest wish as a child? Did it come true?

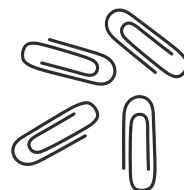
Imagine that they are curious to know how life has been for you since you've grown up.

- What would you tell them first?
- What are the parts of your life that your younger self would be most excited to hear about?
- What parts of your life have not changed much since you were a kid?

Tell them everything here:

[illegible]

Paste your favourite memories from childhood here!

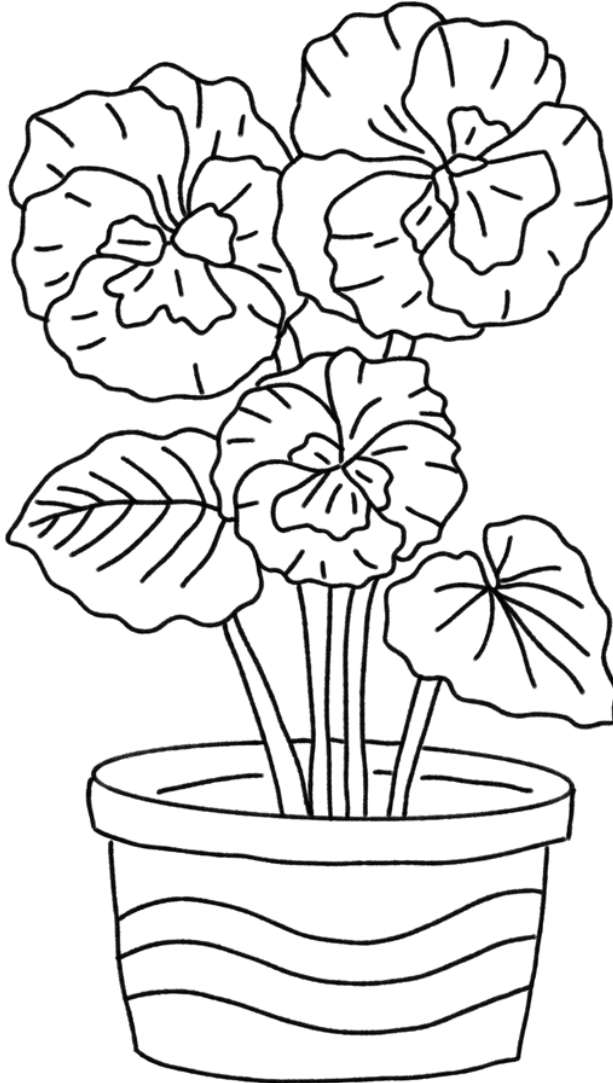


Social Media Break

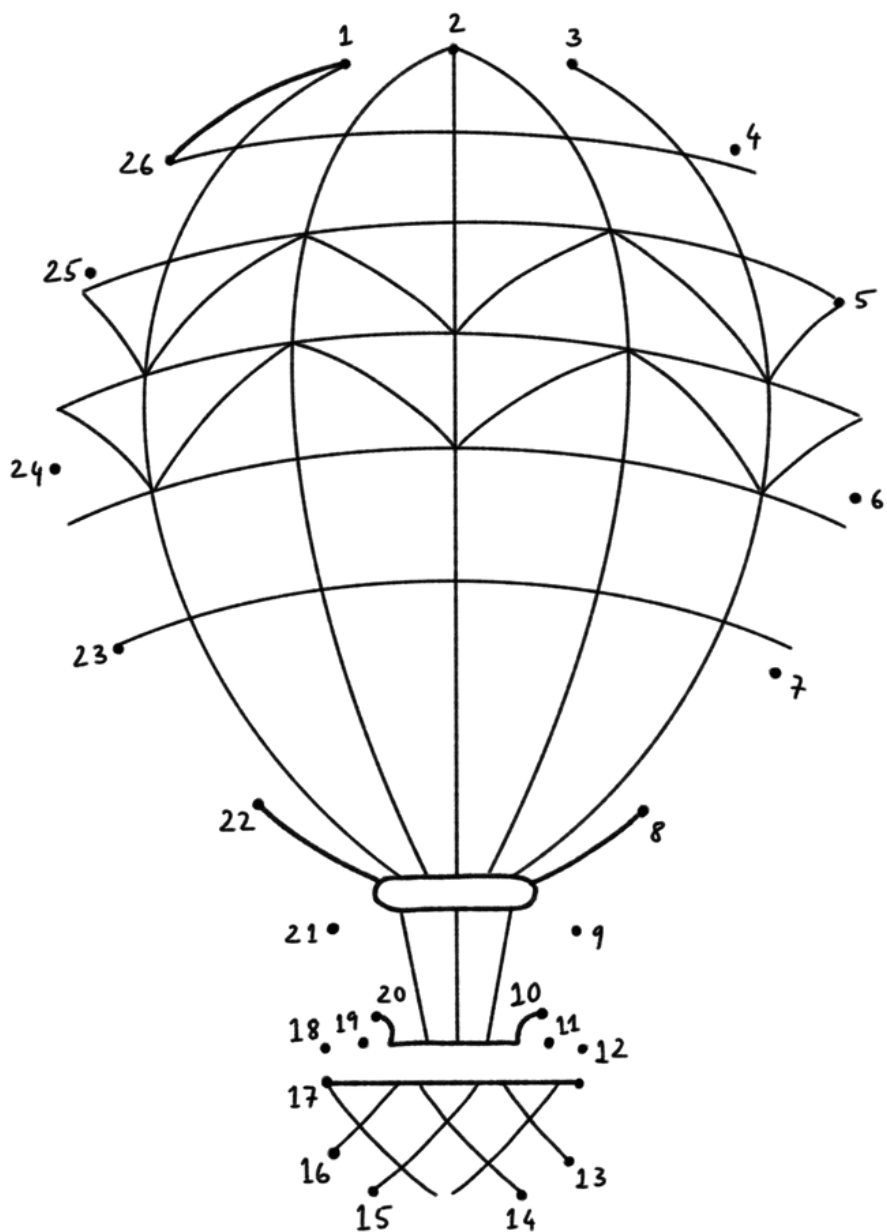
Reflect on your week & color.

Think about all the emotions you felt.

Assign a color to each emotion. Color on the basis of how frequently you felt a particular emotion.



Dot to dot joining



Creative Story Writing

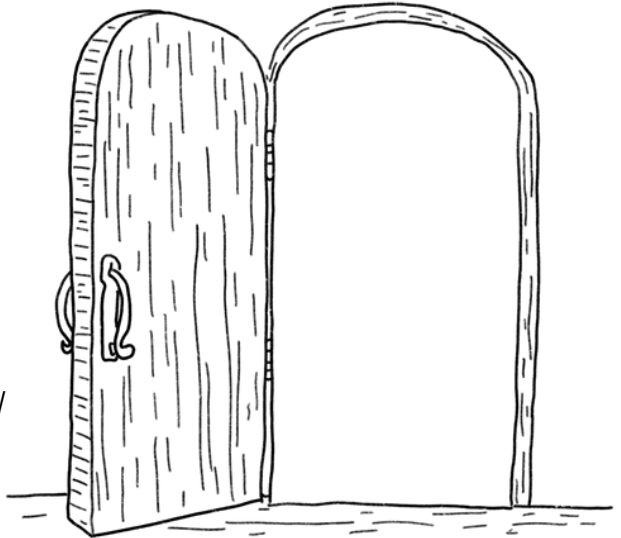
When we are young, we believe that truly anything is possible. As we grow older, we start putting restrictions on ourselves by limiting ourselves to the 'reality'. Let your inner child run today!

1. "What if I said yes?"

Think of a moment you said no to something—an opportunity, a date, a job. Now write a short story imagining what would have happened if you said yes...

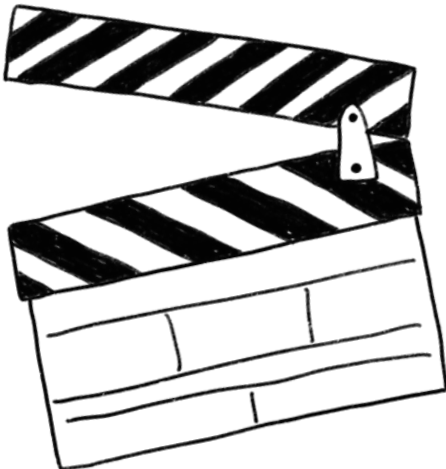
2. The door only I can see

One day, you notice a door in your home/neighborhood/city that no one else seems to see. What happens when you open it?



3. A letter to my future self

Write a letter to yourself five years from now. What do you hope has changed? What do you want to remember?

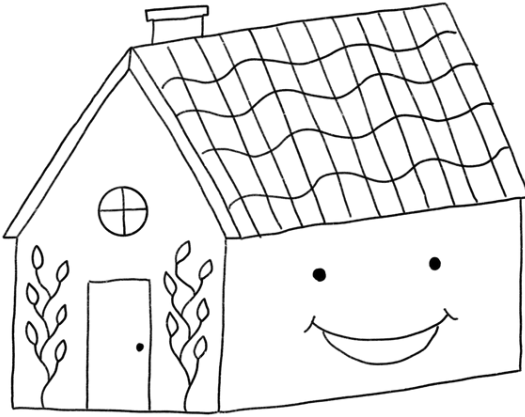


4. The day time froze

Time stops for everyone but you. You have 24 hours before everything resumes. What do you do?

5. My life as a movie scene

Pick a recent moment in your life & rewrite it like it is a scene from a movie. Add music, drama, or humor



6. *If my house could talk*

What would your home say about the life lived inside it?

7. *A stranger changed my day*

Write about a small, unexpected interaction with a stranger that ended up changing your mood or your life ...

8. *The best day that never happened*

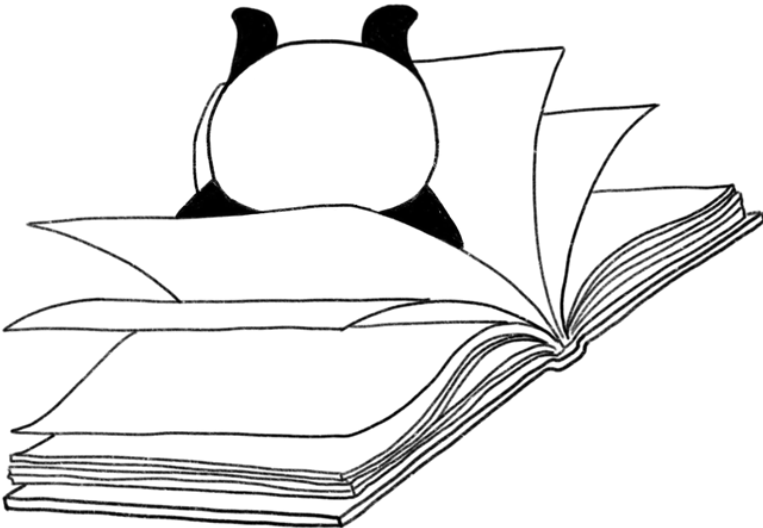
Imagine a perfect day that didn't happen—but could have. Describe it like it did...

9. *My life as a star*

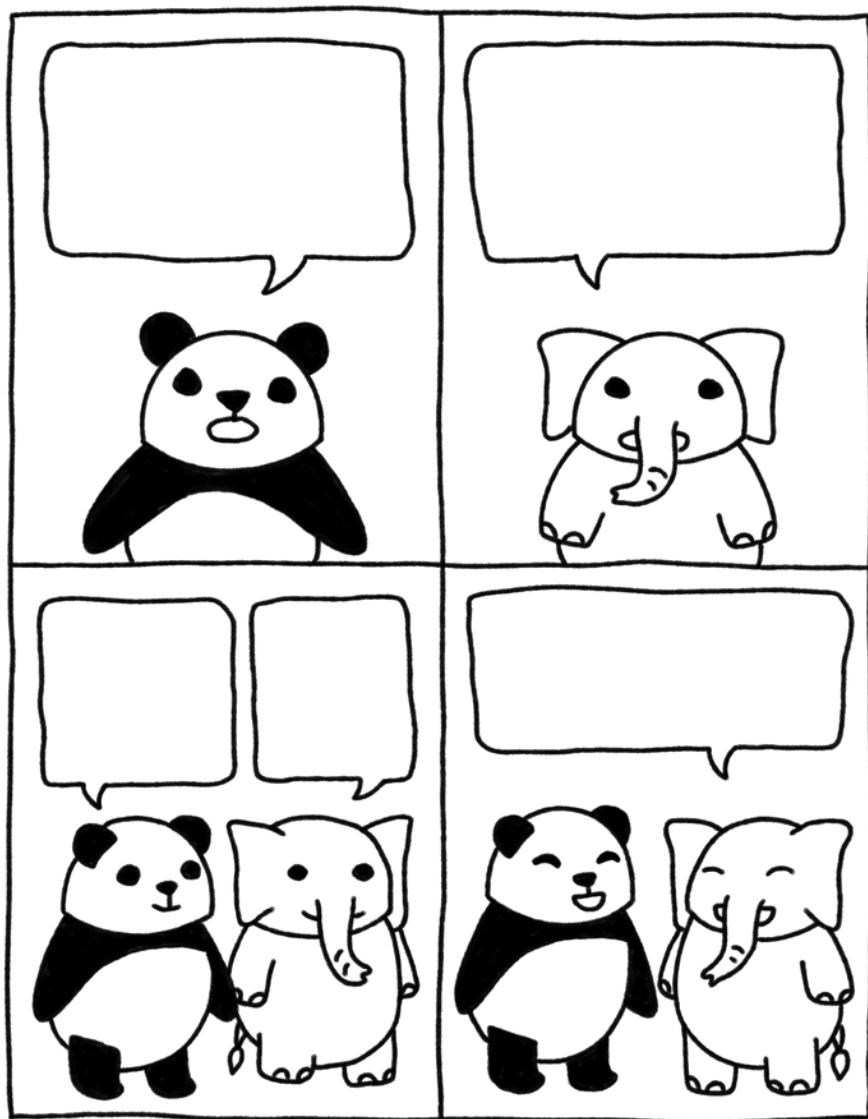
Imagine if you were famous. What would life look like?

10. *I got sucked into a book*

What would happen if you got sucked into your favorite novel? How would the plot get affected? What would you do differently?



Make your own comics



Fun facts

**Bananas are berries,
but strawberries
aren't!**

Talk about an identity
crisis.

**Archaeologists have
found pots of honey in
ancient Egyptian tombs**
that are over 3,000 years
old and still good to eat!

**Cows have best friends
and get stressed when
they're apart.**

Who knew cows were so
emotionally deep?

**Sea otters hold
hands** while they
sleep so they don't
drift apart.

Want to tell me
about your day over
some coffee?



**The shortest war in history
lasted only 38 minutes**

Talk about a quick
resolution!

**Bees sometimes sting
other bees**

Workplace drama is real,
even in the bee world.

Sharks existed before trees

Sharks have been swimming
around for over 400 million years.
The first trees appeared about
350 million years ago!

**A group of flamingos is called
a "flamboyance"**

With a name like that, it's no
wonder they're so fancy!

**There's a basketball court
above the U.S. Supreme
Court**

It's called The Highest Court
in the Land.

Snakes can predict earthquakes

They can sense quakes from up to 5 days before they happen.

An octopus has three hearts

That's triple the love, but also triple the heartbreak!

Bubble wrap was originally intended to be wallpaper

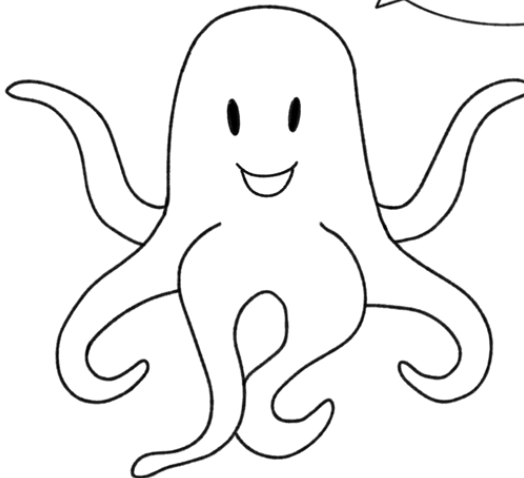
Imagine living in a bubble!

Scotland's national animal is the unicorn

Magical realism at its finest



Let's make this respawn count!



**There's a species of jellyfish
that can live forever**

It's called *Turritopsis dohmii*.

**Some turtles can breathe
through their butts**

Nature finds a way, no
matter how strange

**In Switzerland, it's illegal to
own just one guinea pig**

They get lonely, so you have to
have a pair!

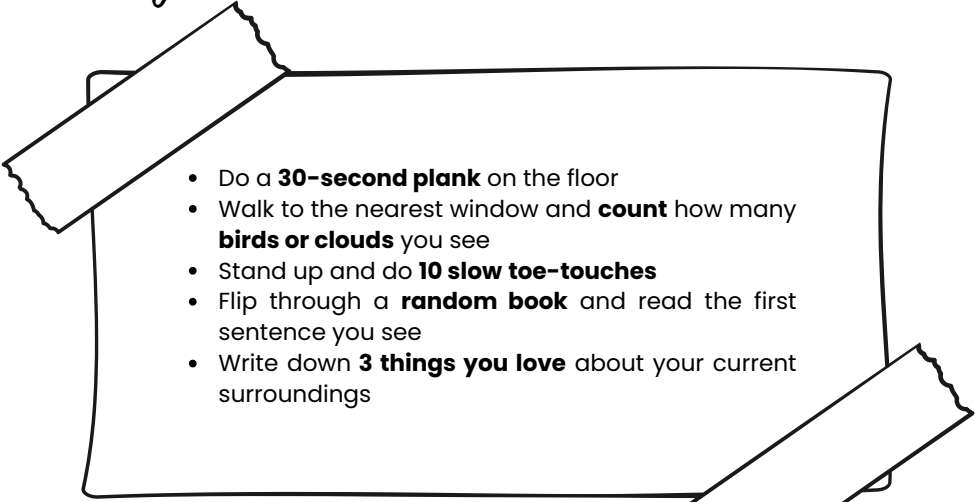
**A snail can sleep for
three years**

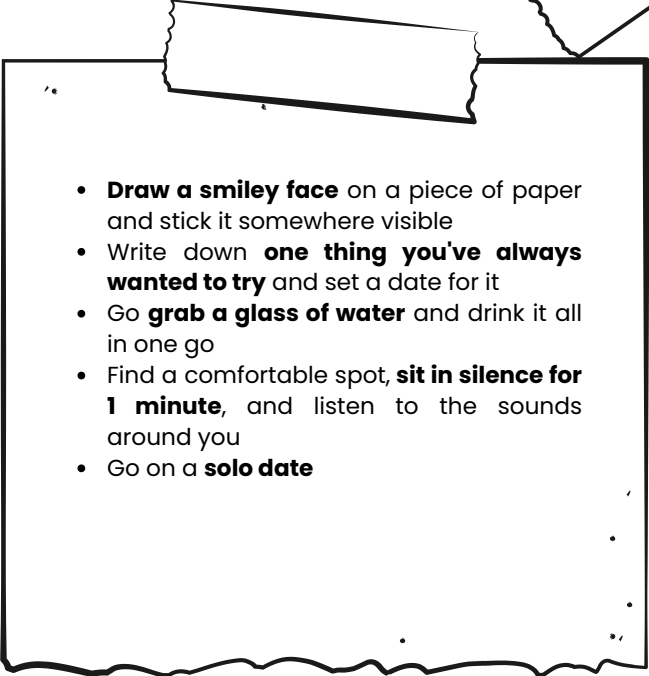
Hitting the snooze
button, big time.

Cats can't taste sweetness

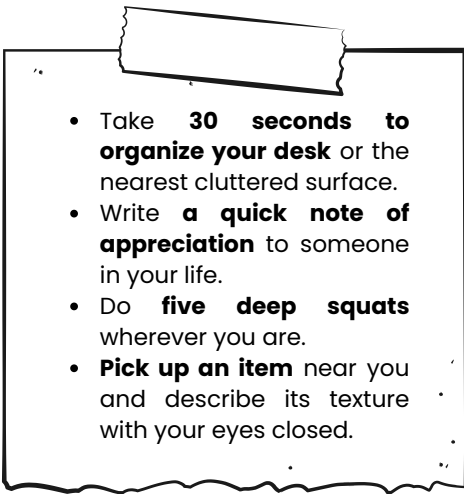
Which explains their
unbothered attitude toward
cake.

I dare you to

- 
- Do a **30-second plank** on the floor
 - Walk to the nearest window and **count** how many **birds or clouds** you see
 - Stand up and do **10 slow toe-touches**
 - Flip through a **random book** and read the first sentence you see
 - Write down **3 things you love** about your current surroundings

- 
- **Draw a smiley face** on a piece of paper and stick it somewhere visible
 - Write down **one thing you've always wanted to try** and set a date for it
 - Go **grab a glass of water** and drink it all in one go
 - Find a comfortable spot, **sit in silence for 1 minute**, and listen to the sounds around you
 - Go on a **solo date**

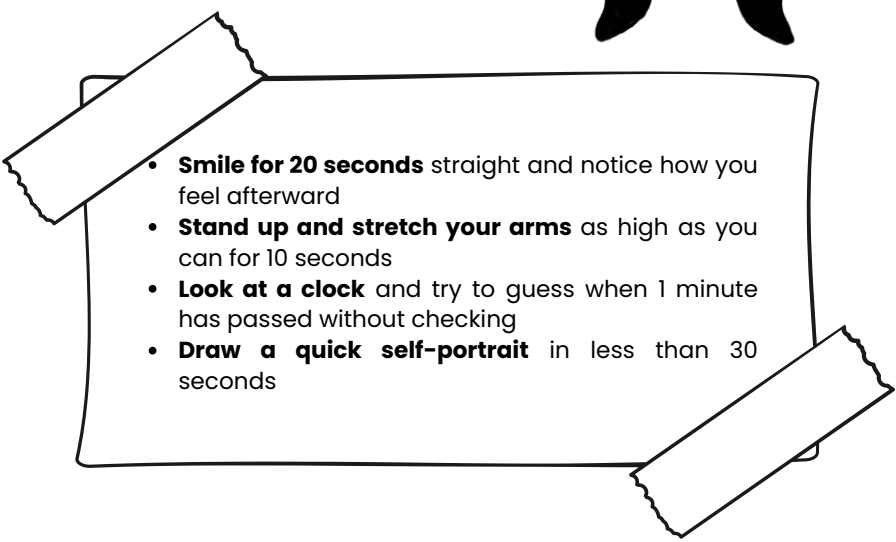
I dare you to

- 
- Take **30 seconds** to **organize your desk** or the nearest cluttered surface.
 - Write **a quick note of appreciation** to someone in your life.
 - Do **five deep squats** wherever you are.
 - **Pick up an item** near you and describe its texture with your eyes closed.



You are doing
so well!



- 
- **Smile for 20 seconds** straight and notice how you feel afterward
 - **Stand up and stretch your arms** as high as you can for 10 seconds
 - **Look at a clock** and try to guess when 1 minute has passed without checking
 - **Draw a quick self-portrait** in less than 30 seconds

Burnout

Word from a therapist

As a professional in the mental health field, I'm exposed to a mix of emotions on a daily basis. Managing these emotions can be a challenge, especially when dealing with frequent, emotionally charged conversations.

To maintain my emotional well-being, I prioritize self-care. When possible, I enjoy traveling and exploring new cultures.

Additionally, I've also developed more accessible routines to help me recharge such as going for walks, spending time in nature, and engaging in hobbies I love. I also make a conscious effort to limit my social media use, especially during emotionally taxing periods.

Journalling has become a valuable tool for me to process my emotions and reflect on my experiences. These self-care practices help me refill my emotional tank, mitigating the risk of burnout and ensuring I can continue to support others with compassion and empathy.

*Love,
Riddhi*



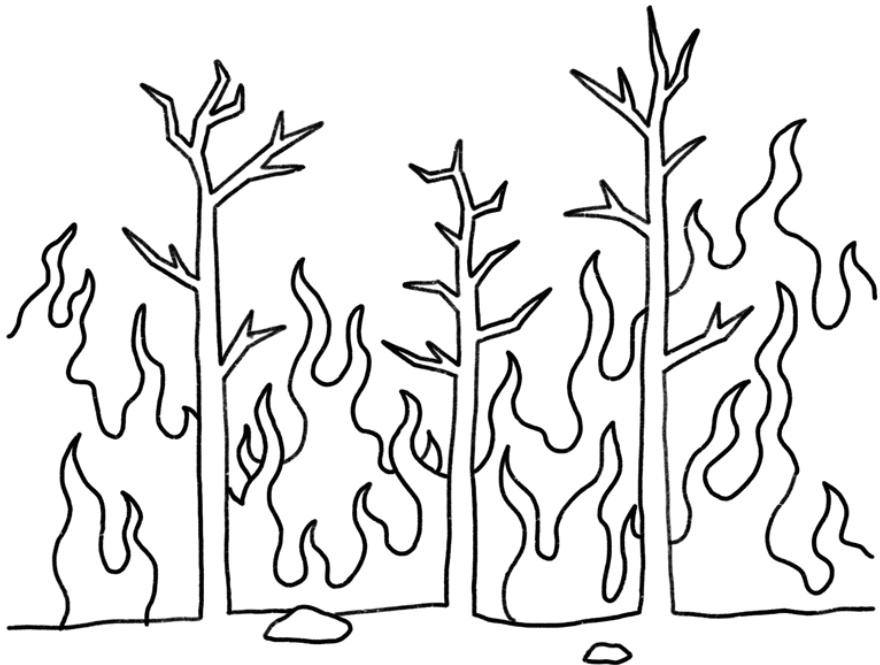
The Flame That Fuels Our Demise

A candle with the highest flames also burns the fastest.

Burnout, simply explained, is when your work is not balanced with rest, stress management, and hobbies.

Our culture promotes “hustling”. We are encouraged to work and discouraged from resting. We compete with each other about who sleeps the least, works the hardest, & brings in the most money.

While it is important for our survival to work; if not balanced with self-care and a sense of community, we often end up feeling lost, hopeless, and demotivated to work.



What is something simple that you always wanted to do but never had the time to?

Make a list of some of those things/activities

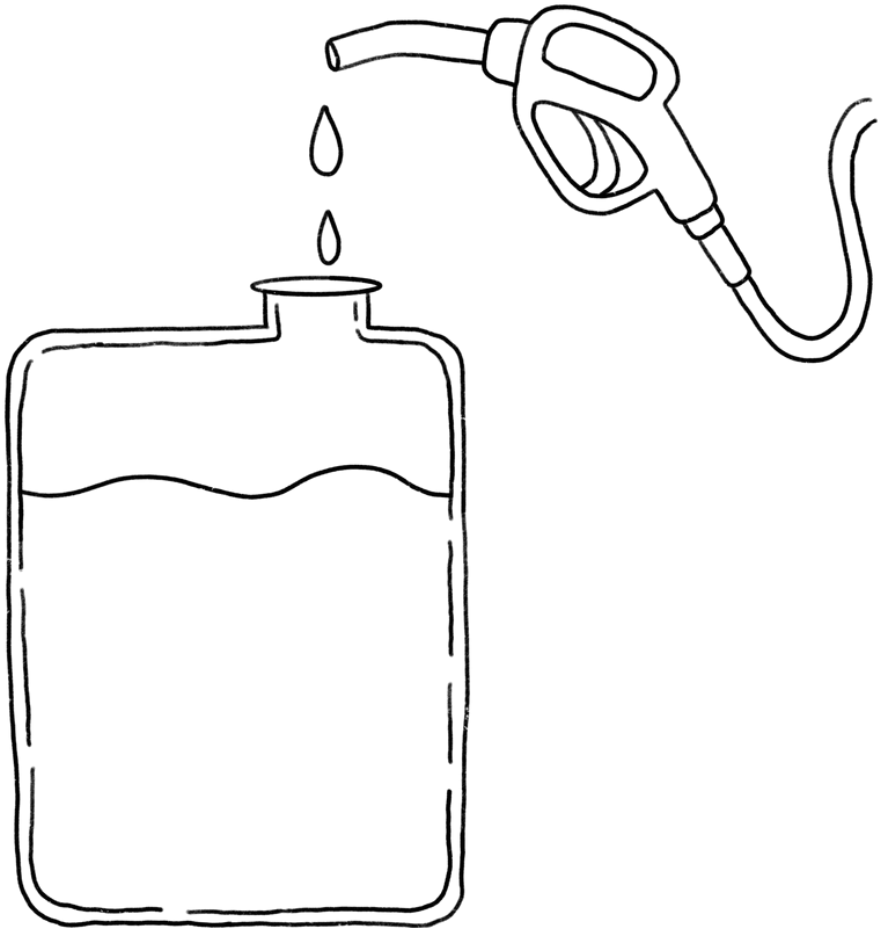
A hand-drawn rectangular box containing eight rows of a radio button followed by a horizontal line, intended for a list.

Out of the above few things, just pick one and take out only 5 minutes of your day to engage in it.

List a few things that can help in refilling your tank!

Just as a vehicle requires regular fueling to operate efficiently, humans need periodic breaks to replenish their emotional, mental, and physical resources.

The notion that we can persist indefinitely without rest is a recipe for burnout.



Grounding

Word from a therapist

I've always been someone who has felt the weight of anxiety in high-pressure situations. Over the years though, I've practiced this trusted technique to calm my nerves and ground myself in the present:

The Grounding '54321' exercise.

Whenever I feel overwhelmed, I take a few deep breaths and focus on my surroundings, noticing:



5 things I can touch



4 things I can see



3 things I can hear



2 things I can smell



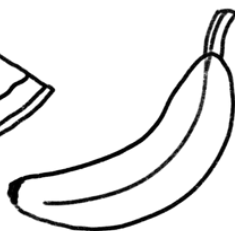
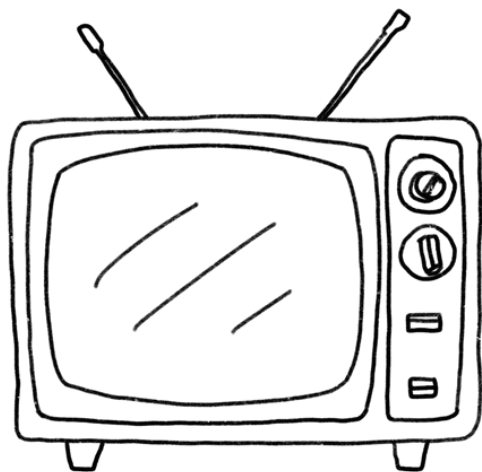
1 thing I can taste

This simple exercise has been a lifesaver for me; helping me regain control and approach challenges with clarity and calm. It's a reminder that no matter what's happening around me, I have the power to stay present and centered.

*Love,
Riddhi*

Let's practice mindfulness

- Choose at least three of the categories here (movies, sports teams, animals, countries, colors, cities, books, cars, tv shows, fruits, vegetables, famous people, etc.) and name as many items as you can in each one. Spend a few minutes on each category to come up with as many items as possible.

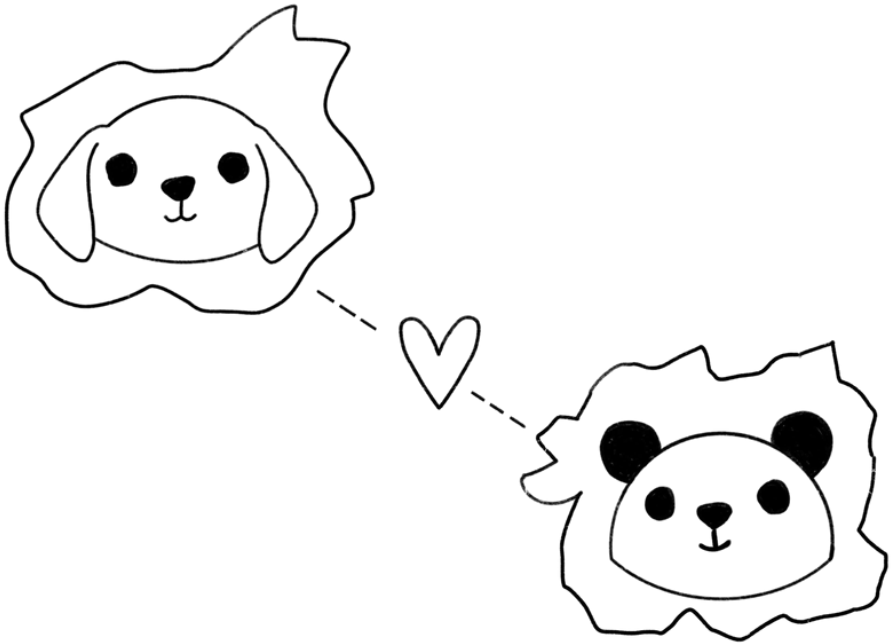


- Count backwards from 100 by 7
- Pick up an object and describe it in detail. Describe its color, texture, size, weight, scent, and any other qualities you notice
- Spell your full name, and the names of three other people, backwards
- Name all your family members, their ages, and one of their favourite activities
- Read something backwards, letter by letter. Practice for at least a few minutes

Acceptance

Word from a therapist

Acceptance has arguably been the most important tool for me. I'll never forget the lesson I learned during a pivotal moment in my long-term relationship. When my partner got accepted into a prestigious program in another city, I was ecstatic for him, but terrified for myself. The thought of navigating a long-distance relationship for three years felt daunting.

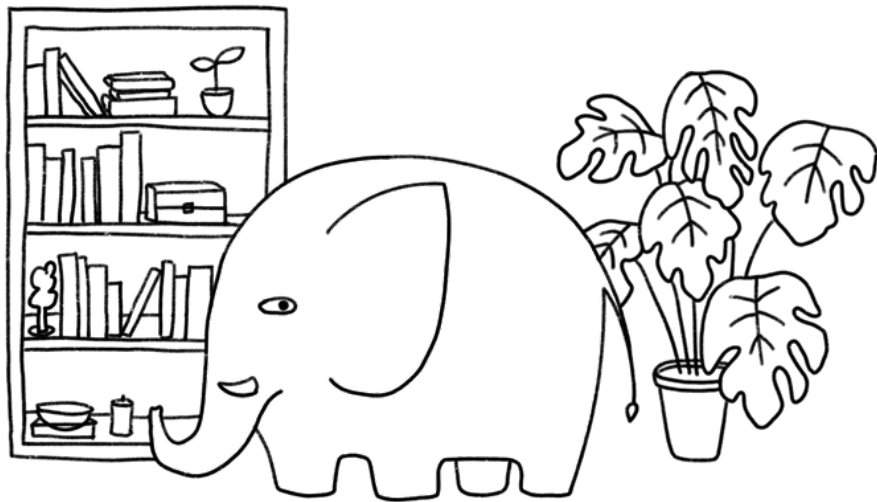


After the initial shock, I took a step back, processed my emotions, and accepted our new reality. Some thing shifted. I transitioned from a place of fear and uncertainty to one of curiosity and excitement. My partner and I started exploring ways to bridge the distance, from regular video calls to planning visits. Those three years weren't easy, but they were transformative. We grew individually and together, and our relationship deepened in ways I never thought possible.

Looking back, I realize that acceptance was the catalyst for that growth. By embracing our situation, rather than resisting it, we open ourselves up to new experiences, lessons, and love.

Imagine this

You are stuck in a room with a pink elephant, what's the first step that you will take in order to deal with such a situation?



P.S. Feel free to color this elephant!

No matter how you respond to the situation, the first step is ALWAYS acknowledging the fact that there is a pink elephant.

As soon as one accepts or acknowledges the situation, we are finally able to change or fix it.

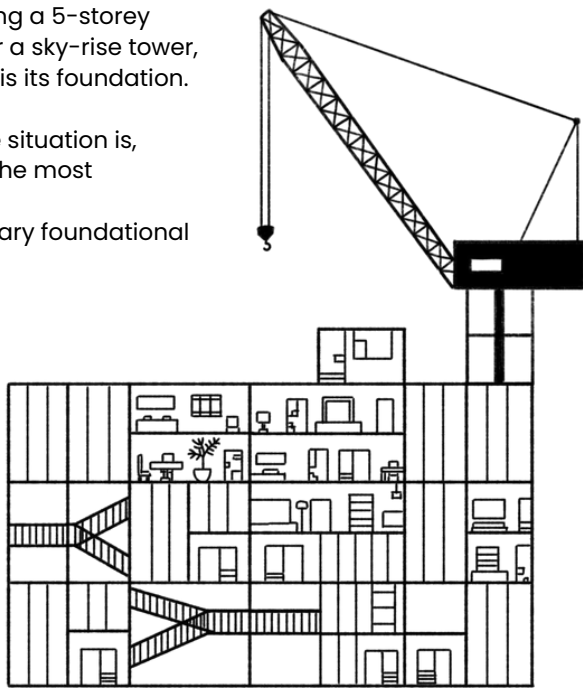
Hence, acceptance becomes one of the most basic steps to deal with any kind of situation. Denial can lead to pain and acceptance can lead to peace.

*Love,
Riddhi*

Whether we are building a 5-storey building, a mansion, or a sky-rise tower, the most integral part is its foundation.

Similarly, whatever the situation is, acceptance remains the most

important and necessary foundational step!

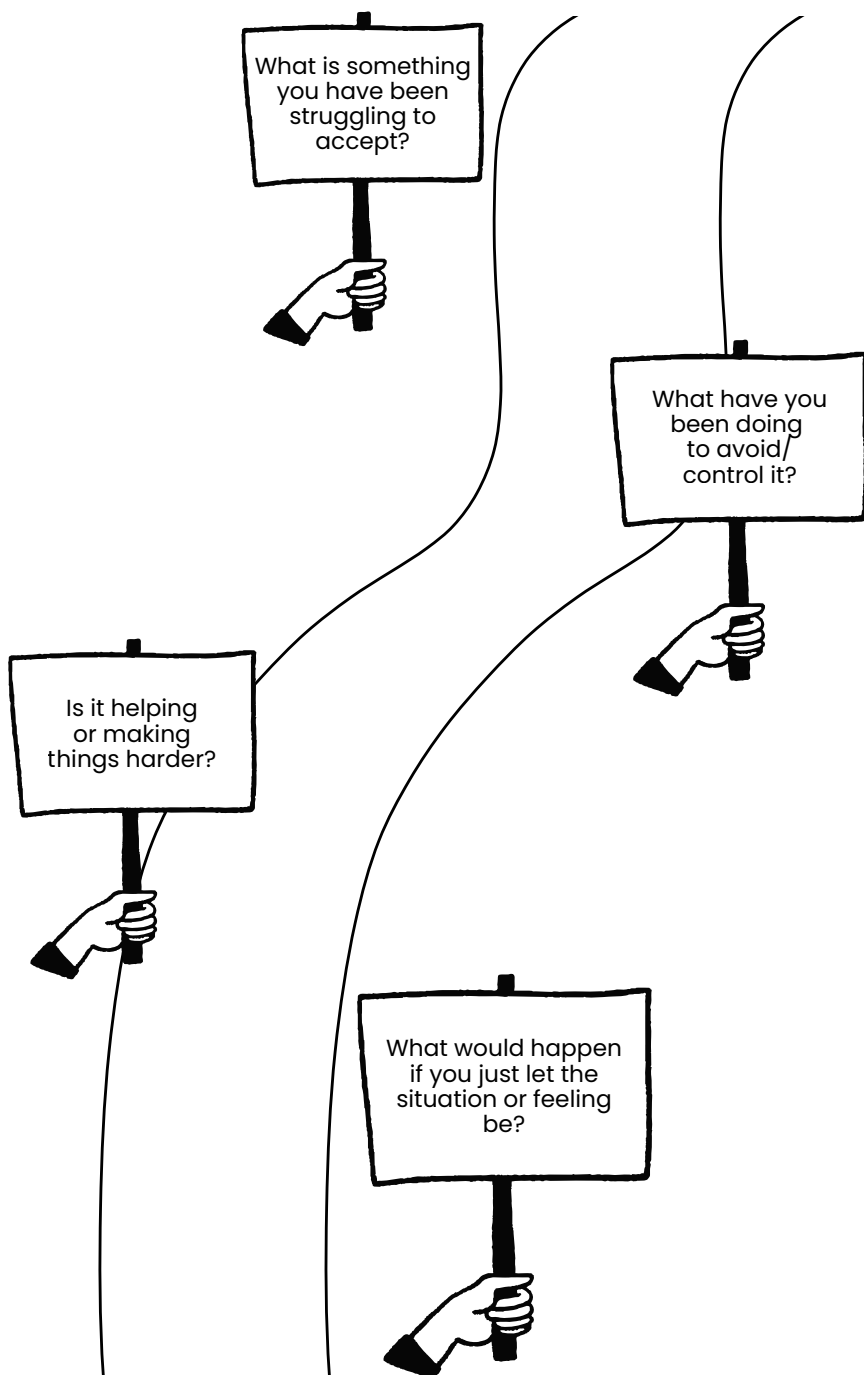


Take a deep breath & say this out loud...

I accept what I cannot change..

What didn't happen wasn't supposed to..

I make peace with the story of my life..

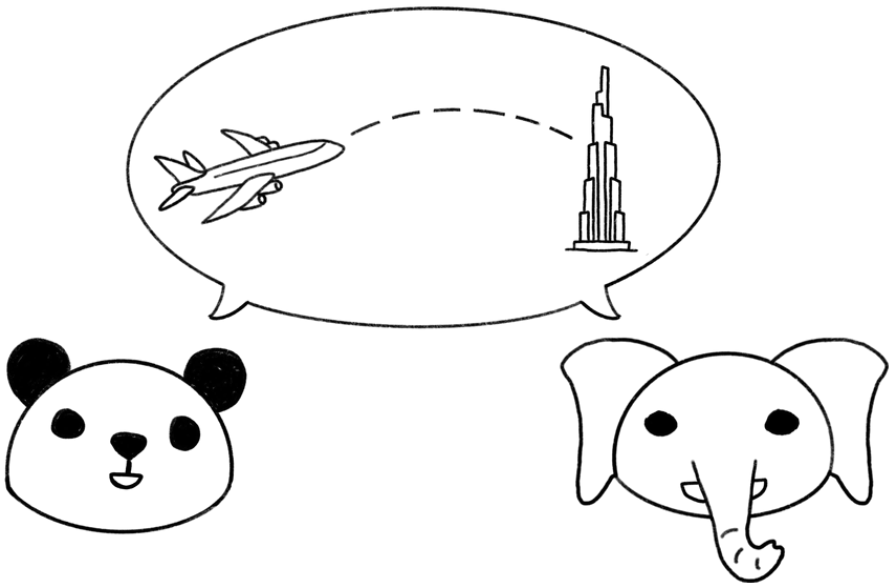


Goals & Dreams

Word from a therapist

Ushma and I share a special bond, rooted in our shared middle-class background and passion for growth. Our journey together began with internships at a hospital, where we commuted together, sharing dreams and aspirations. Those conversations sparked a fire within us, fueling our determination to achieve our goals.

Even as students, we envisioned a brighter future; discussing projects, collaborations, and international travel. One of our earliest goals was to embark on a self-financed trip abroad. We made that a reality with a memorable trip to Dubai. That experience reinforced the power of goal-setting. We employed techniques like mind mapping, solution-focused approaches, and regular reflections to stay focused. Today, I'm proud to say that our shared aspirations have helped us achieve milestones, including publishing our journal together.



For Ushma and myself, having goals has been instrumental in giving our lives direction and purpose. Our experiences have taught us that with teamwork, and a clear vision, we can overcome any obstacle and achieve greatness.

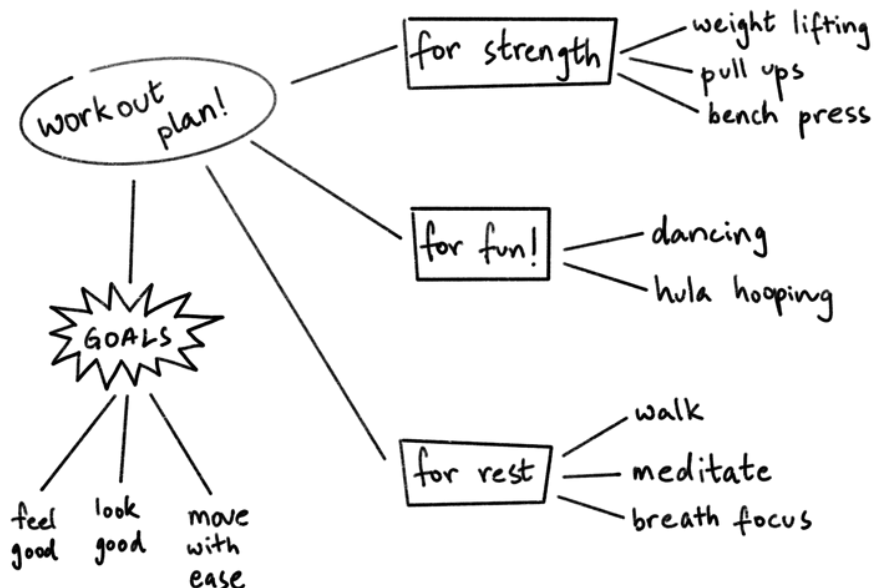
Having dreams and goals in life is essential for giving meaning to one's existence. It inspires motivation, boosts confidence and helps overcome procrastination and fear. By setting clear objectives, we can stay focused, disciplined, and creative, ultimately gaining a sense of control and agency over our lives.

*Love,
Riddhi*

Mind mapping

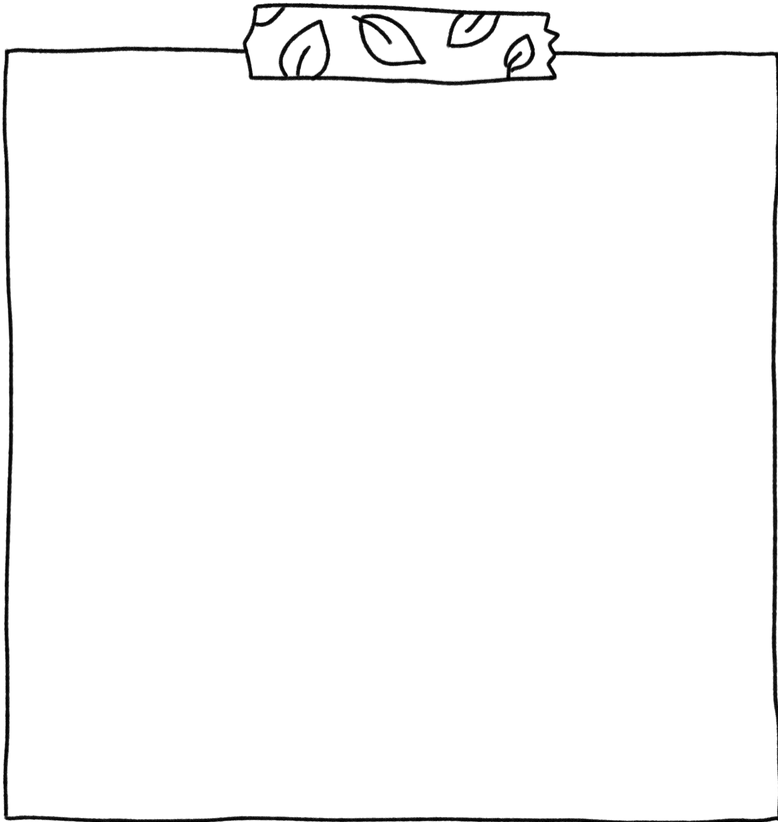
Visualize your goals and ideas using a mind map. This technique helps generate and organise ideas, making it easier to create a plan.

It would look something like this



Letter to future self

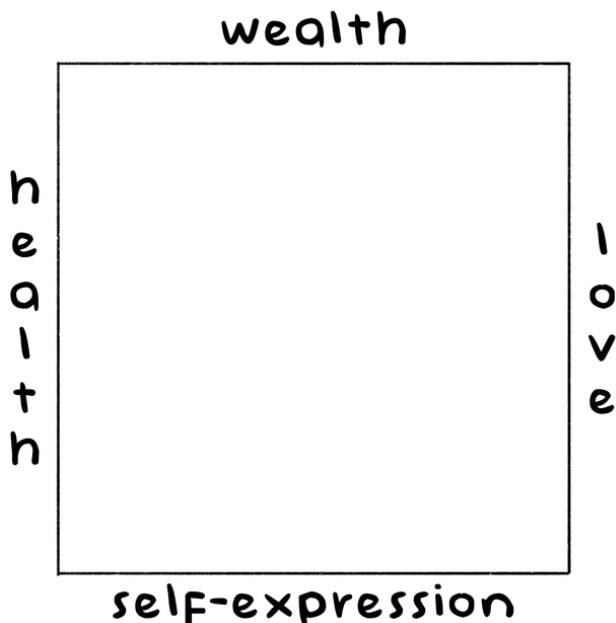
To form your goals, start by reflecting on your current life, values, and aspirations. Imagine yourself 1–5 years from now and what your ideal life looks like. Then, write a letter to your future self describing your vision, goals, and aspirations. Be specific, honest, and kind, and include what you want to achieve, why, and how you plan to overcome obstacles.



Set a reminder to read it on a specific date in the future. When you read it, reflect on your progress, celebrate successes, and identify areas for improvement. Revise your goals and strategies as needed. This activity will help you clarify your goals, stay focused, and achieve your aspirations. Reading this letter will not only give you confidence in the present but also give you immense sense of achievement and satisfaction in future.

Perfect square

Includes wealth (finances), health (physical, mental, emotional and spiritual), love (love for ourselves, having fulfilling and loving relationships) and self-expression (it can include the ways we would indulge ourselves into expressing our emotions, feelings etc. It can be through art, singing, dancing etc.)



Vision board

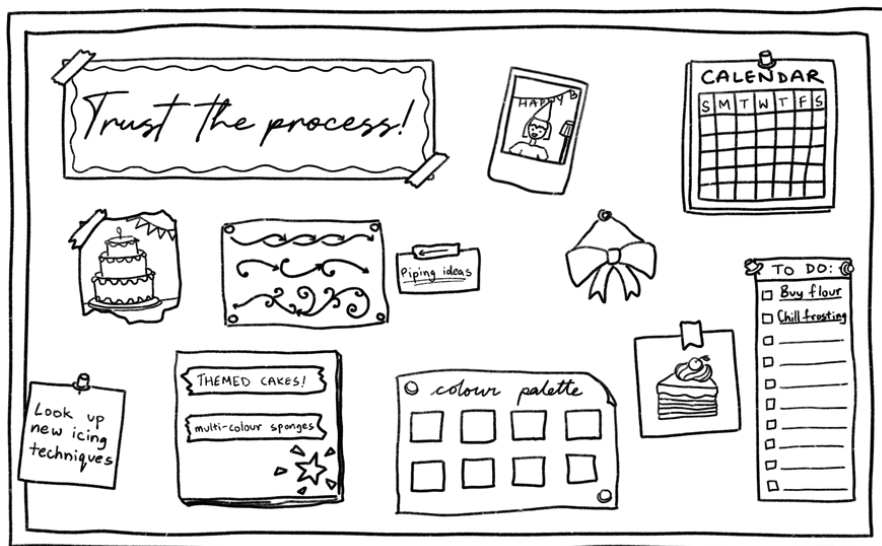
Based on the points that you have mentioned in the perfect square, try to make a vision board reflecting the same. To start, gather your magic makers: old magazines, scissors, a glue stick, markers or colored pens, a board or paper of any size, and photographs or printed quotes if you like. Next, take a moment to dream big! Close your eyes and imagine your ideal life—think about your goals, desires, and passions. What makes you happy? What do you want to achieve?

Now, flip through those magazines and cut out images and words that resonate with your dreams. Look for colors, textures, and patterns that evoke emotions and inspire you. Don't worry too much about why you're drawn to something; just trust your instincts. As you cut out your inspirations, start arranging them on your board in a way that feels intuitive, group similar themes together or create a collage – it's up to you!

- Add some personal touches to make your vision board truly special.
- Write inspiring quotes or affirmations with markers, add photographs or personal symbols, and make it your own.
- Don't be afraid to get creative and experiment with different layouts and designs.
- When you're happy with your arrangement, glue everything in place and take a step back to admire your creation.
- Finally, display your vision board in a place where you'll see it daily, and let it remind you of your goals and inspire you to take action.

Remember, your vision board is a personal reflection of your desires, so don't worry about perfection - focus on the feeling!

By following these simple steps, you'll have a beautiful and powerful tool to help you manifest your dreams and make them a reality.

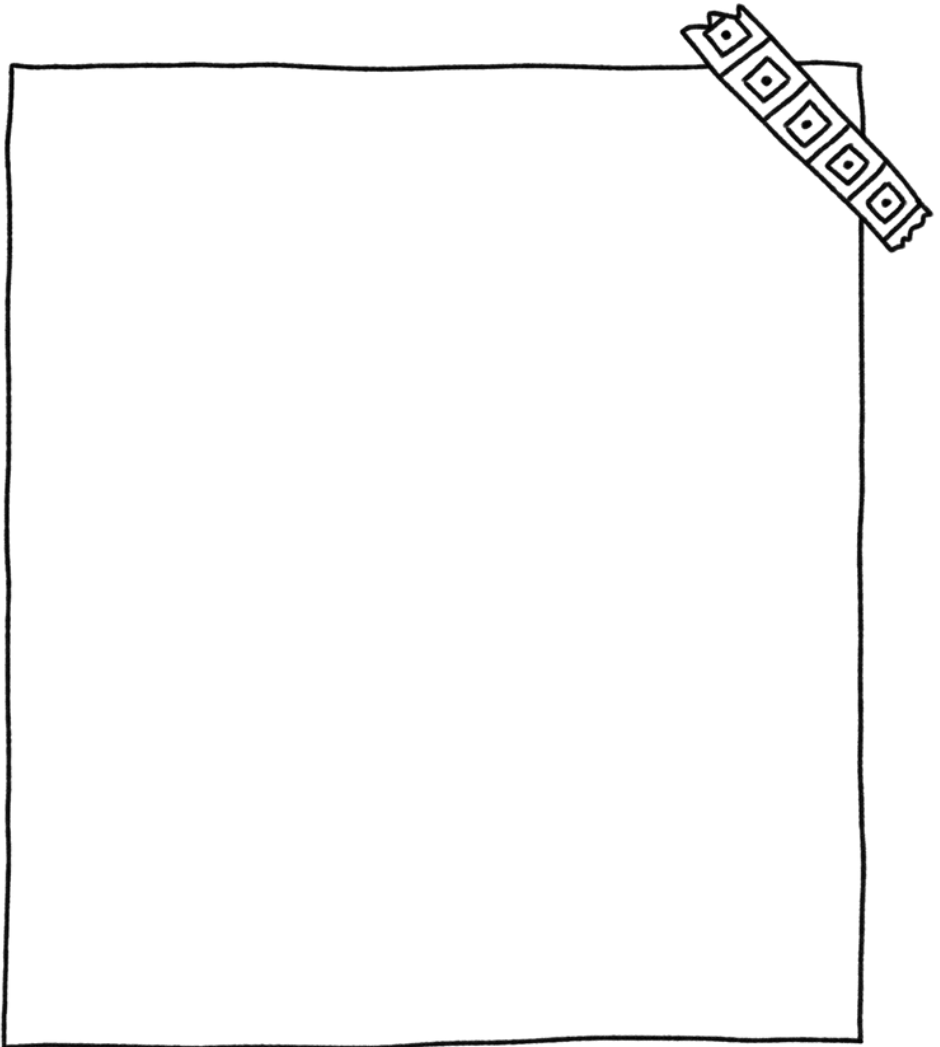


Visualization

Imagine yourself achieving your goals and dreams. Visualization helps strengthen your motivation, focus and commitment.

Backward goal setting

1. Define your end goal
2. What would be the last step before that goal is achieved?
3. Work backwards, one step at a time



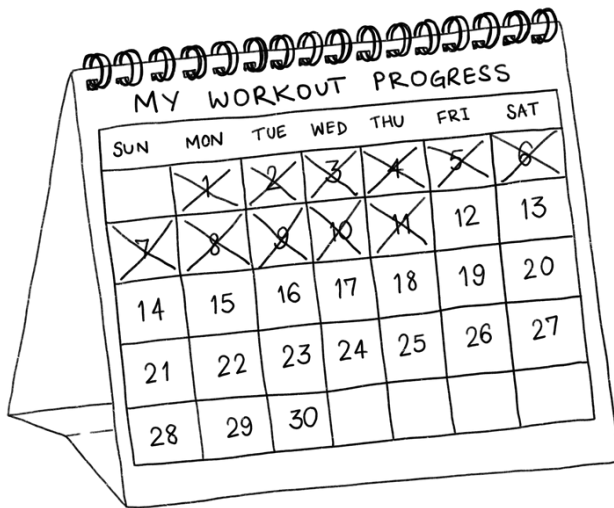
Habit Formation

Word from a therapist

Developing self-discipline has been a journey for me, especially when it comes to prioritizing my physical and emotional well-being. To cultivate healthier habits, I've established a reward system that motivates me to stay on track. My goal is to maintain a balanced diet and regular exercise routine.

To achieve this, I've created two charts to monitor my progress:

One chart for gym sessions and another for healthy eating. Each day I meet my targets, I earn a token.



At the end of the month, I tally up my tokens. My benchmark is 25 successful days out of 30. If I reach this goal in both diet and exercise, I treat myself to something special – whether it's a shopping spree, a movie date with my partner, or a cheat day.

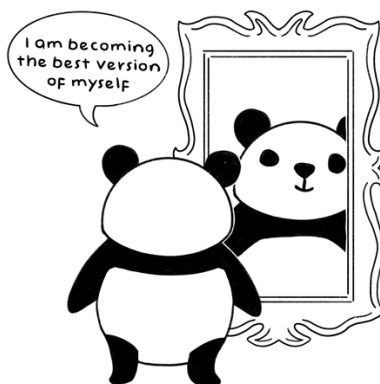
This reward system has been instrumental in helping me stay committed to my wellness goals. By acknowledging and celebrating my small wins, I've found the motivation to prioritize my health and well-being.

*Love,
Riddhi*

The most effective way to change your habits is to focus not on **WHAT** you want to achieve, but on **WHO** you wish to become. Changing the way you see yourself leads to lasting changes in behavior.

Define your identity

- **Technique:** Shift your focus from **WHAT you want to achieve (goals)** to **WHO you want to become (identity)**
- **Example:** Instead of saying, "I want to run a marathon," reframe it as "I am a runner."
- **Why it works:** Identity-based habits are more sustainable. When you view yourself as a certain type of person (e.g. a healthy eater or regular exerciser), your behaviors naturally align with that identity.



Reduce Friction (Make it Easy)

- **Technique:** Remove obstacles that make it harder to perform the habit.
- **Example:** If you want to start reading more, keep a book by your bed or on your couch so it's easy to get up. If you want to eat healthier, keep healthy snacks visible and accessible.
- **Why does it work?** The more friction there is between you and your desired behavior, the less likely you are to follow through. Reducing barriers makes it easier to complete the habit.

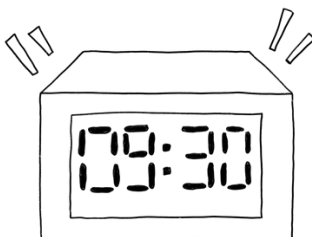
Visualize Success

- **Technique:** Regularly visualize yourself successfully performing the habit.
- **Example:** Imagine yourself enjoying your run, feeling energized, and accomplishing your fitness goals.
- **Why it works:** Visualization strengthens the neural pathways associated with the behavior, making it more likely that you'll act in line with that image.



Make it Consistent (Same Time, Same Place)

- **Technique:** Perform the habit at the same time and in the same context each day.
- **Example:** If you want to exercise more, do it at the same time every day (eg, first thing in the morning, right after work) and in a designated space (eg, a home gym or park).
- **Why it works:** Habits are often triggered by specific cues in the environment. Consistency builds an automatic link between the behavior and its context, making it easier to remember and do the habit over time.



Make it Enjoyable (Use Positive Reinforcement)

- **Technique.** Attach positive rewards to the habit, or make the process itself enjoyable.
- **Example:** If you're trying to develop a habit of running, listen to your favorite podcast or music while you run.
- **Why it works:** Positive reinforcement strengthens the behavior, making you more likely to repeat it. If you associate the new habit with something enjoyable, your brain will seek out that pleasure, reinforcing the habit.

For instance:

Give yourself tiny tokens each time you do that activity, and then after a cluster of tokens, use it to get a bigger reward for yourself.

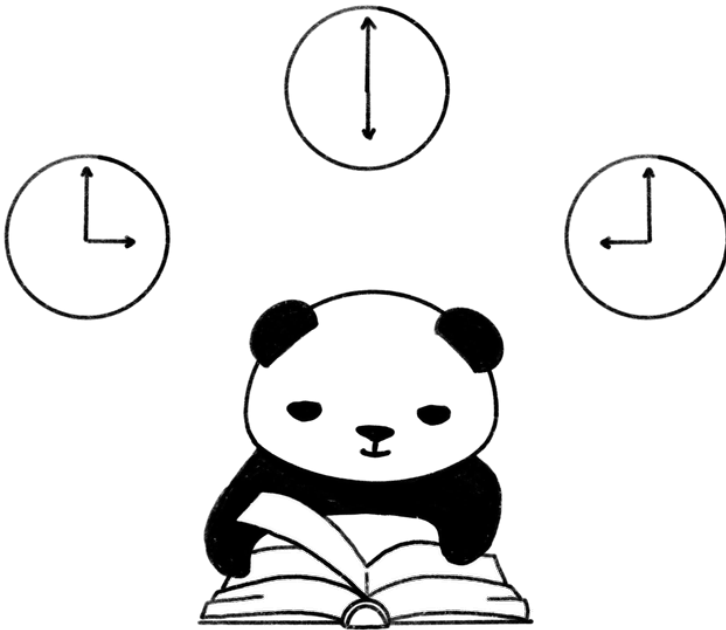
For example, every time you hit a gym (target behavior) give a small token to yourself. As soon as you collect at least 4 tokens in a week, take yourself out to do something that you like, movies, shoes, etc. could be good options or rewards.

Target behaviour: _____

The Joy of Flow

You know that feeling when you're doing something you love, and time just seems to vanish? Like, one moment it's noon, and the next, the sun is setting, and you've barely noticed? That magical state of being completely absorbed in what you're doing is called flow, a term coined by the psychologist, *Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi*.

Flow is like being in the zone— where everything clicks, and you feel unstoppable. It's not about doing something easy (that gets boring fast!) or something impossibly hard (hello, frustration!). It's about finding that perfect challenge that keeps you hooked.



Think about it: a baker might lose themselves in kneading the dough until it's just right, or a gamer might get so wrapped up in leveling up that they forget to eat lunch. A runner might hit their stride and suddenly feel like they could keep going forever, or an artist might find themselves painting until they realize it's 3 a.m.

The best part? Flow isn't reserved for big, impressive moments. It can happen when you're doodling, organizing your closet, or even cooking a new recipe. It's that sweet, satisfying feeling of being fully present and loving every second.

How I found my flow...

Word from a therapist

Picture this: It's the last year of college and you still have no idea what to do with your life.

Yes, that was me.

Some of my friends always knew and some figured it out as they learned. I, on the other hand, was completely aimless. Because of my lack of direction, I didn't take exams seriously and didn't make it into Psychology class. The last seat closed at 86.80% and I had 86.78%.

I ended up in a Literature class instead.

7 days passed and I hated being in class. Not much interested me. Just then, someone dropped out of Psychology! I ended up getting the seat.

On the 1st day of class, our teacher, Ms. Suchitra, starts talking about the origins of Psychology. I was fully engrossed.

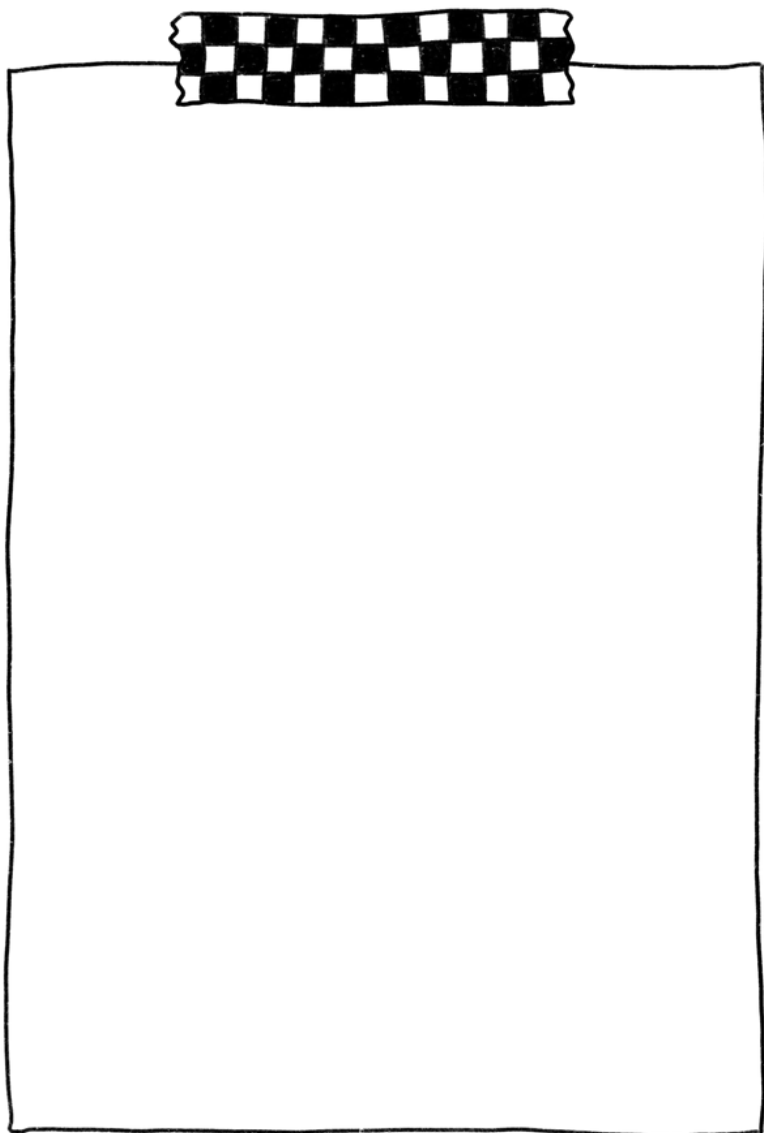
6 hours of classes and I didn't know how time passed by. I loved every moment of this super difficult course. That's how I found my flow. 6 years since then, I've found multiple things that make me flow: such as travel, playing the guitar, painting, & of course, working on this project.

Love,
Ushma



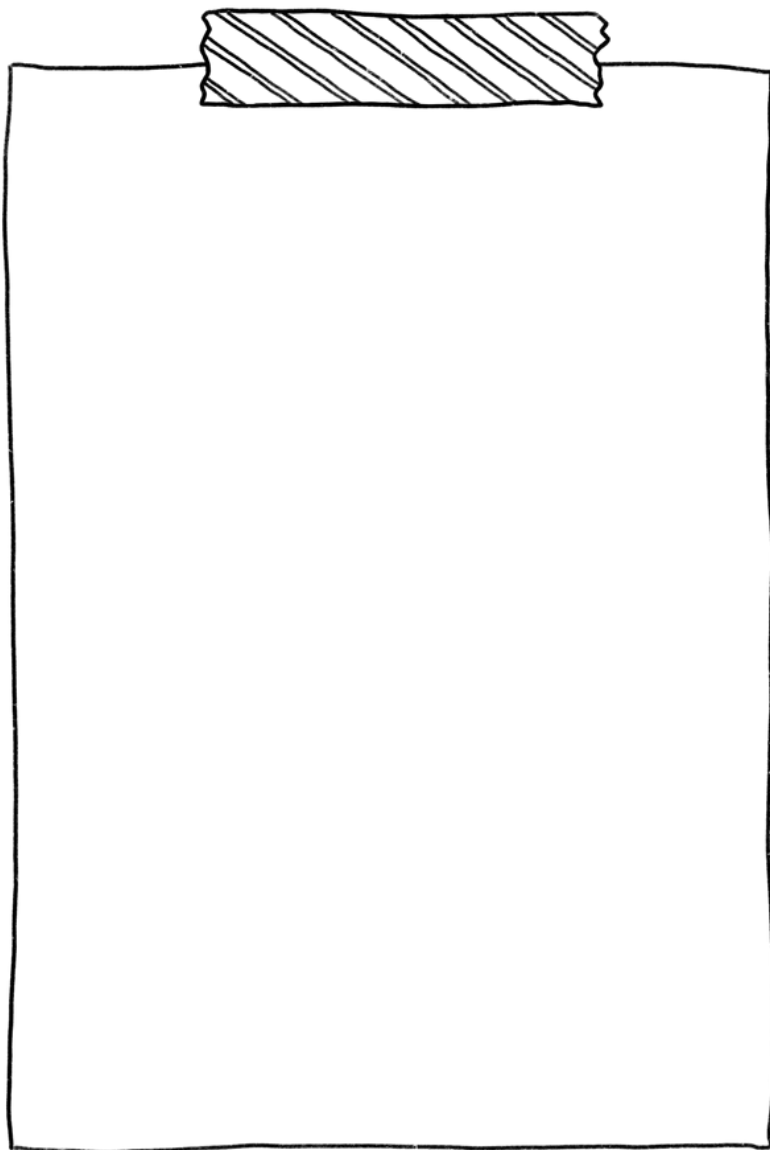
Let's help you find your flow!

Imagine your perfect day where time flies because you're doing something you love. **Sketch** or **write** about what you'd be doing, where you'd be, and how it makes you feel alive.



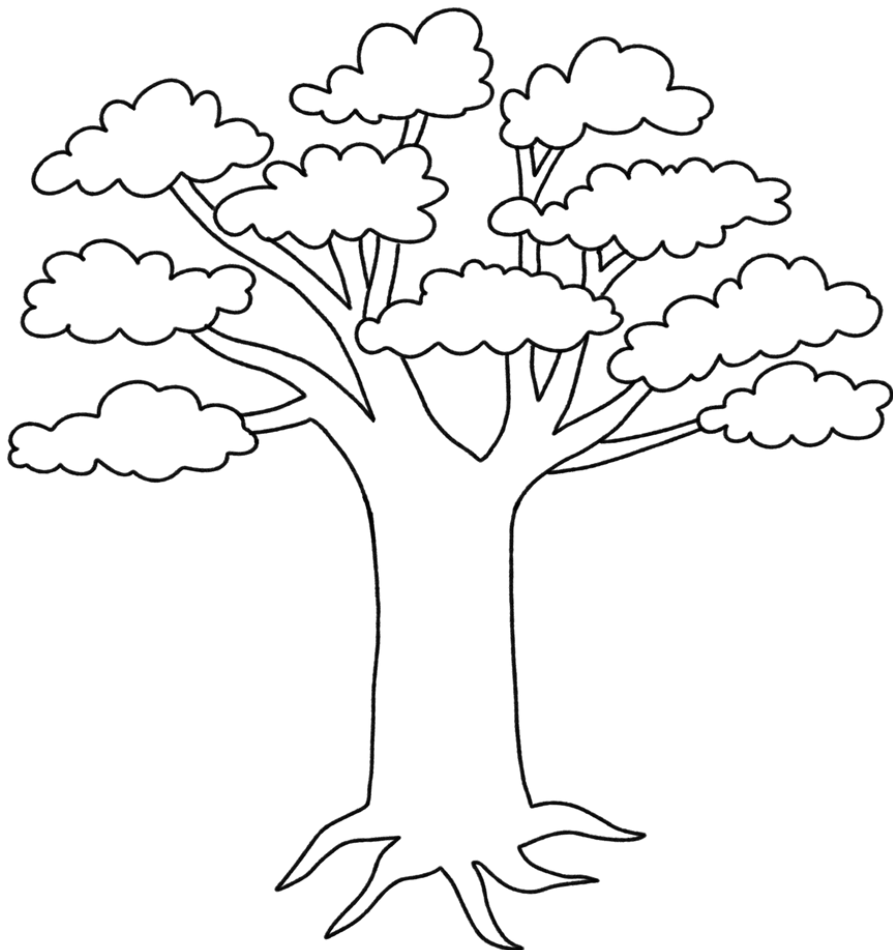
Of what you have written, which parts could be integrated into your current reality on a day-to-day basis?

For example: If your ideal day looks like being amidst nature, how can you incorporate that into your everyday life?



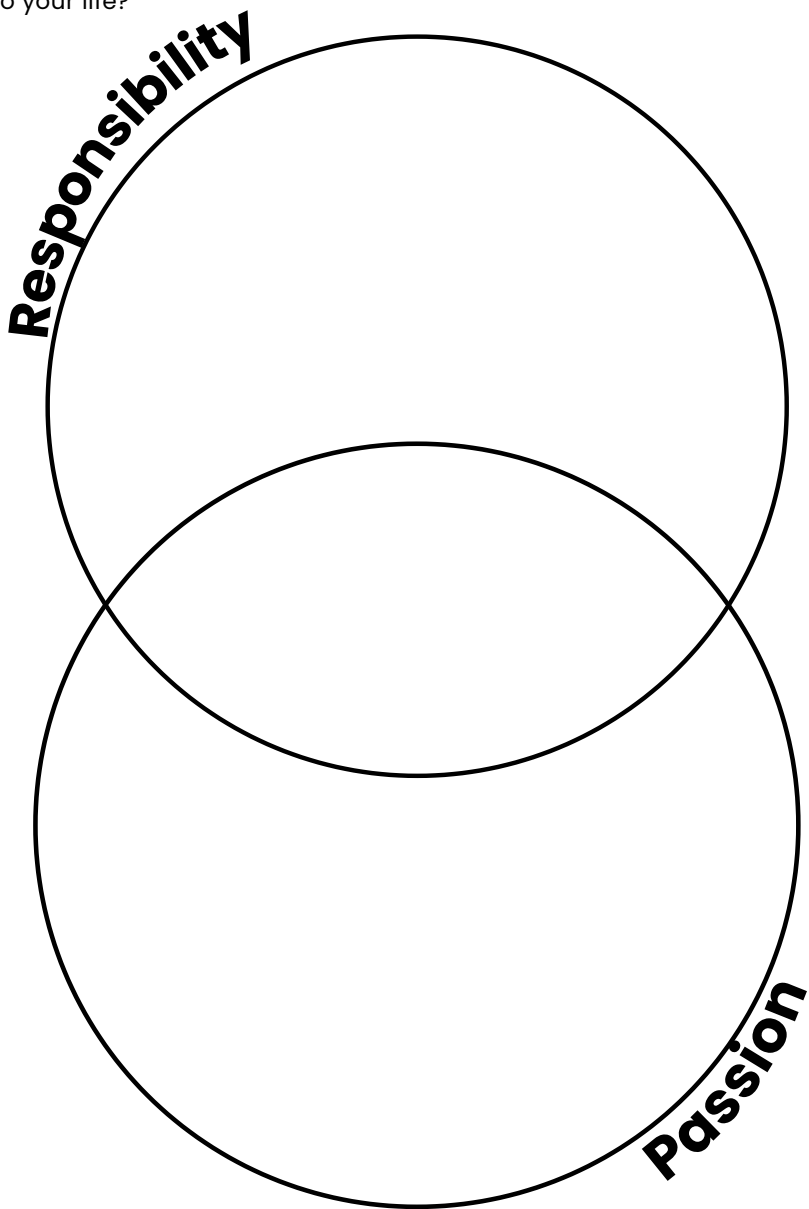
If your life were a tree

Each branch would represent something that makes you feel deeply engaged. Write as many activities that come to your mind. Use colors - Go Crazy!



Finding the middle ground

Imagine a day where your responsibilities intersect effortlessly along with your passions. What small change could you make to bring that balance into your life?



Forgiveness & Letting Go

Word from a therapist

A personal experience that taught me the importance of letting go was dealing with hurtful actions from a family member. Despite our close bond and fond childhood memories, their behavior caused me significant emotional pain. I held onto this hurt for a long time, unaware of the internal toll it was taking.

I eventually realized that clinging to this negativity was hurting me more than anyone else. To begin my healing process, I wrote an unsent letter to this family member, expressing my emotions and thoughts. This therapeutic exercise helped me process and release some of the intensity of my feelings.



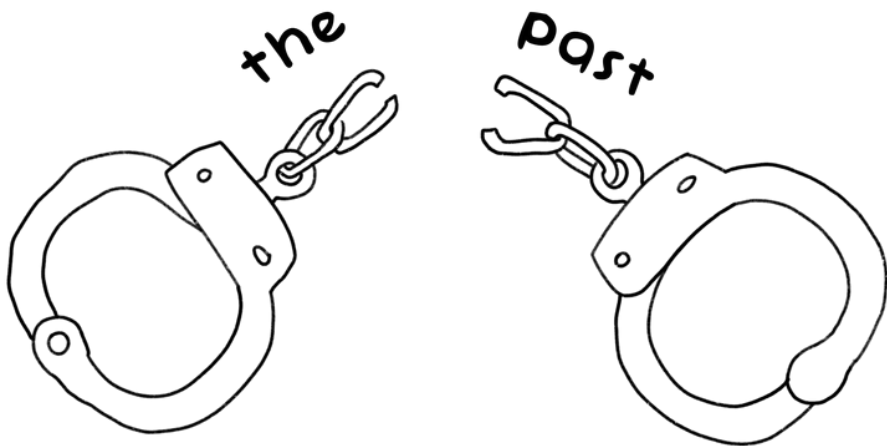
I then took it a step further by tearing down the letter into smaller pieces, allowing me to confront and release each emotion individually. While the scars still remain, I no longer hold onto the hurt. This experience taught me that letting go is not about erasing memories or forgiving others, but about releasing the emotional burden that holds us back.

Holding onto resentment and anger can consume us, weighing heavily on our minds, hearts, and spirits. The act of forgiveness and letting go is a powerful step towards healing, freedom, and inner peace. It's not about forgetting or condoning past hurts, but about releasing the negative emotions associated with them. By choosing to forgive and let go, we can break free from the shackles of resentment and anger, allowing ourselves to move forward with greater ease, compassion, and understanding.

"Holding on to anger is like drinking poison and expecting to kill the other person"

That's exactly what resentment usually does to us. It sometimes makes us bitter in a very gradual manner. When we are holding resentment towards our own selves, it's important to acknowledge those emotions and at the same time, deal with them by reminding ourselves that we are just humans at the end of the day.

Love,
Riddhi

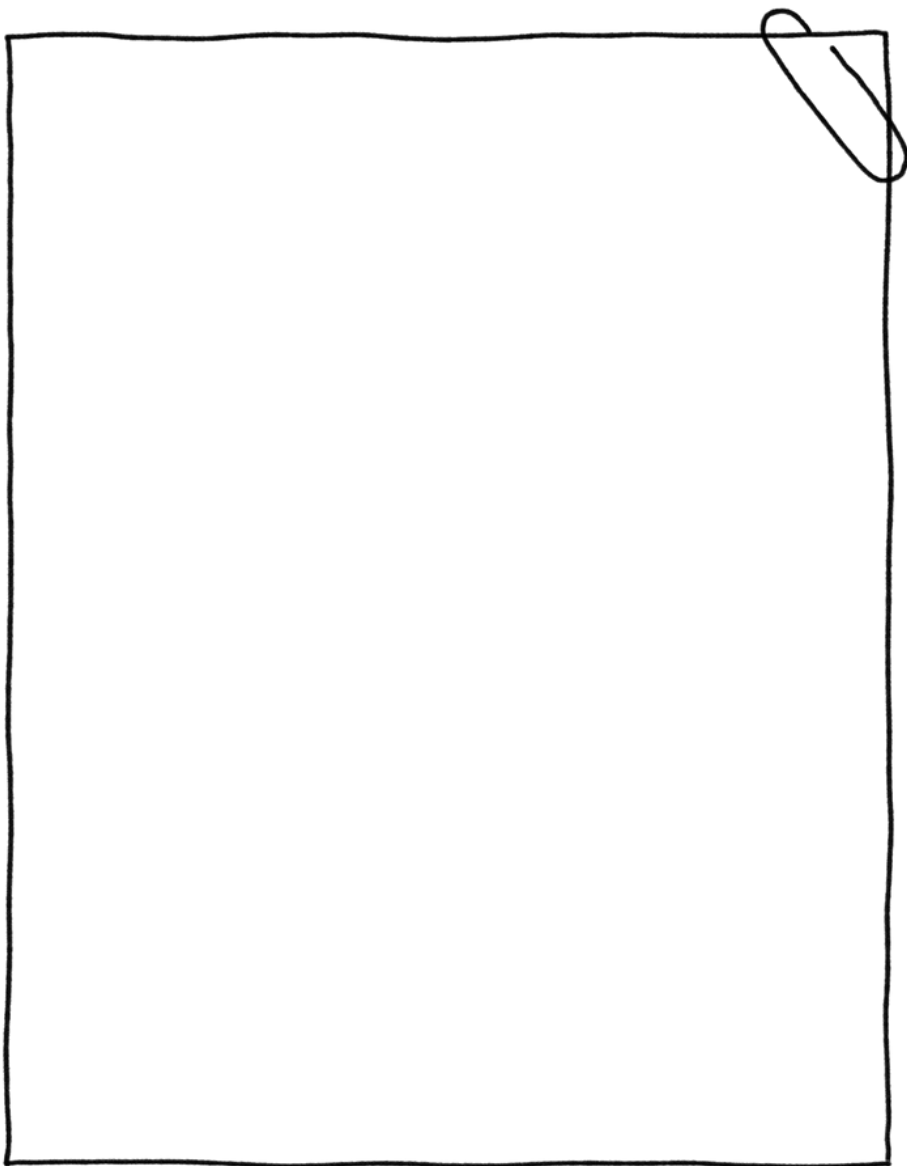


"It's okay to look at your past, just don't stare for too long"

Write a letter to yourself

Write a letter to your past self. Pen down any resentment you hold towards that version of yourself. Release it, eventually.

Try to be as nurturing and kind towards yourself as possible.

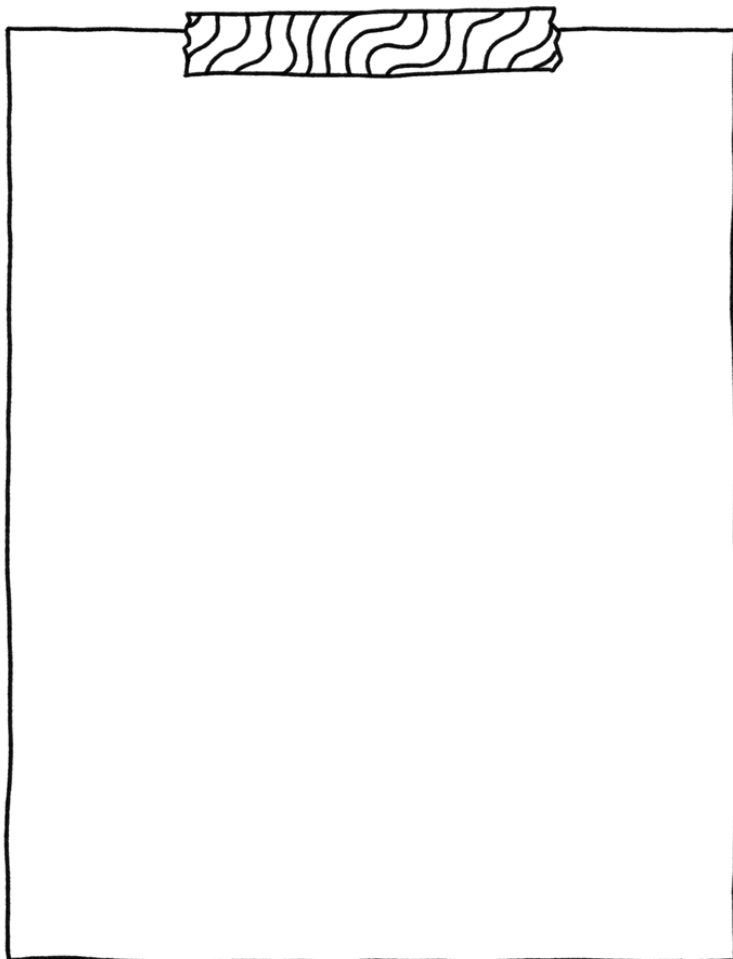


A Therapeutic Letter: Releasing Emotions and Letting Go

Write a heartfelt letter to the one who has hurt you, expressing your unfiltered thoughts and emotions. This cathartic exercise allows you to process your feelings, release pent-up emotions, and begin to let go. By putting your thoughts into words, you can:

- Acknowledge your pain
- Release emotional burdens
- Begin the healing process
- Reclaim your mental peace

Remember, this letter is for your eyes only.



Gratitude

Word from a therapist

Gratitude has been a transformative force in my life, and I'd like to share a humbling experience that deepened my connection with this practice. During my college days, I volunteered with an NGO called Thank You India, which collaborated with the Thane traffic police to promote gratitude and positivity.

Our research project involved distributing 'Thank You' tickets to citizens who followed traffic rules, rather than issuing 'challans'. This simple yet innovative approach had a profound impact on both the recipients and the traffic police officers. I vividly remember one instance where a traffic police officer gave a 'Thank You' ticket to a bus driver for wearing his seatbelt. The entire bus erupted in applause, and the driver's eyes lit up with tears of joy.



Our study found that expressing gratitude in such situations significantly reduced stress levels among traffic police officers. For me, gratitude is more than just a practice – it's a mindset that has stayed with me since my college days. It's a powerful reminder that even small acts of kindness and appreciation can have a profound impact on ourselves and those around us.

*Love,
Riddhi*

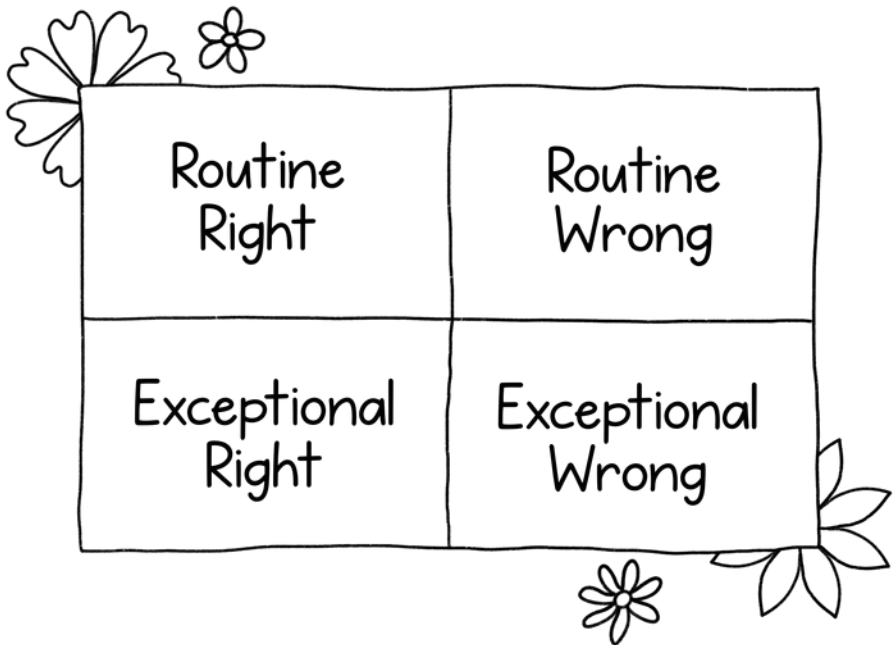
Examples and consequences:

Exceptional Right: Student coming first in his grade → Celebration in the form of party or gifts

Exceptional Wrong : Robbery, Murder, etc → Legal actions like imprisonment

Routine Wrong: Lying to my friend about ETA → Friend getting upset or a little bit of guilt?

Routine Right: Following traffic signals. Getting to board the regular train. Having electricity during work from home → We tend to take these things for granted



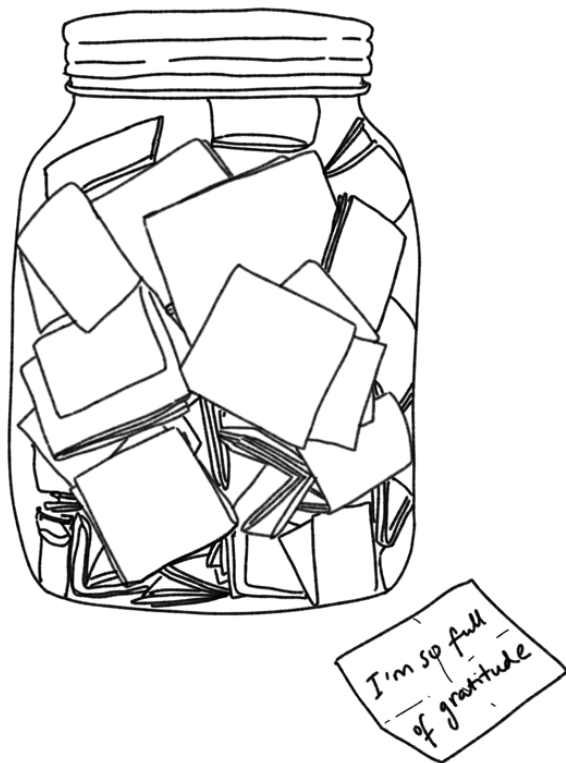
Let's take a pause and observe around ourselves:

- What are the things that are a part of our routine and are going in the right direction?
- Can we list down at least three of these things?

"Gratitude helps you fall in love with the life you already have"

Gratitude jar

All you require is, jar, pens, papers, and some decorative materials. Start by decorating a jar or a box you like, try to exercise your inner child by being as creative as possible. Everyday, think of 3 things that you are grateful for. It can be coffee from your favourite place, favourite meal that a loved one cooked for you or any achievement on that day. Write them on small chits of paper and fill up the jar! Over time you'll have a jar full of reasons to be thankful for what you have and enjoy the life you are living.



If you are ever feeling down, not your best emotionally or mentally, and need a quick tool kit or pick-me-up, take a few notes out of the jar to remind yourself who and what is good in your life. It will definitely bring a smile on your face and make you feel better.

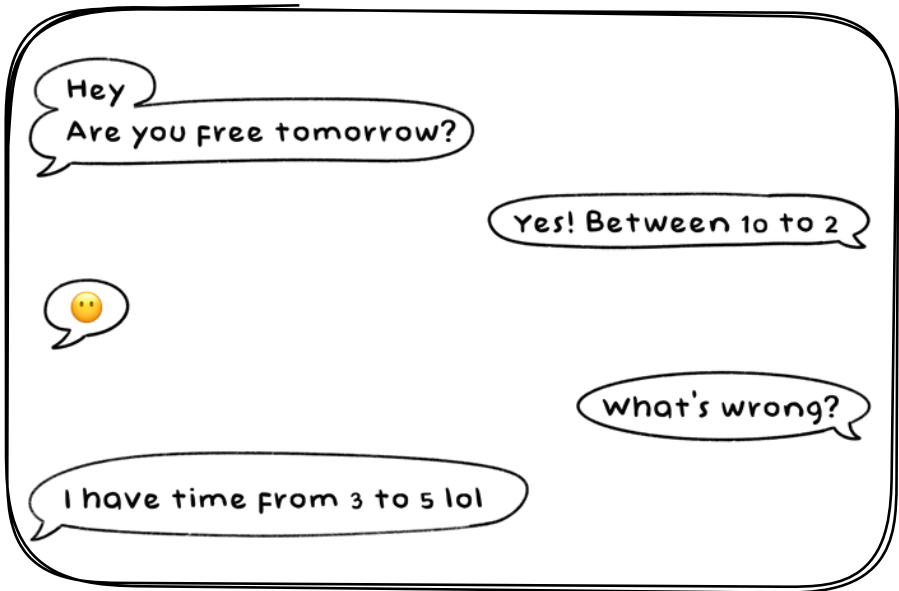
Letter of gratitude

Write a gratitude letter to someone special

	To,
	Thankyou for being my
	I appreciate you because
	I think you are special because
	You make me laugh when
	I have fun with you when
	You are important to me because
	When I think about you, I feel

Navigating Adult Friendships

Word from a therapist



Friendship as 20-something year olds

"I wish there was a way to know you're in the good old days before you've left them" -Andrew Bernard, The Office

Adulthood can be lonely. You go from meeting your friends every day at school to meeting them whenever time permits (and it rarely does). Friends start moving away, getting married, working +80 hours a week & most importantly, trying to get their lives together. Schedules misalign & interests change. Sometimes you drift apart because you've outgrown each other. Ironically, even though all of these experiences are universal, they feel isolating.

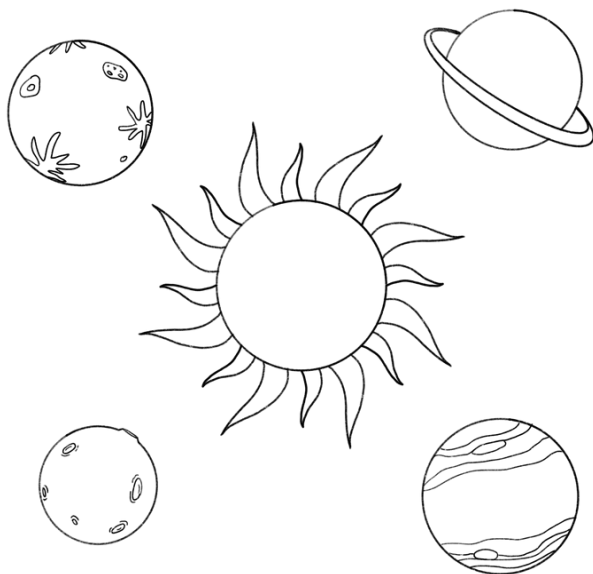
So how do I, as a full-time working professional, navigate through my friendships? It's not simple OR fool-proof, but I am proud to say that I have friendships that I've been lucky enough to maintain even during the toughest phases of my life.

1. Learn the art of detachment

This is possibly the most useful (yet counterintuitive) piece of advice I can give you. Accept that your friends will have different priorities as they grow older & that doesn't mean that they don't care about you. Learn to detach from the unrealistic expectations you may have & watch how beautifully you're able to hold on to friendships. My healthiest friendships are those that foster mutual respect & boundaries. Detach from the idea that you can only do things when someone is experiencing them with you. I am now able to go to cafes, concerts & even trips, alone.

2. Identify your 'core' friendships

I have a system that helps me prioritize friendships and preserve my energy. Your core friends are the people who know you in and out, can be trusted with your deepest secrets, and have your best interests. Peripheral friends are those that I might exchange pleasantries with at a social gathering once in a while, or meet up for a coffee annually but would not trust with my life. This distinction helps me manage my expectations from different people in my life.



3. Express gratitude

I come from a typical Indian family. We don't verbally express love to each other, ever. On the contrary, my friends are some of the most expressive people I know. I empathise with you if you're thinking to yourself- Um, this is awkward. I don't think I can be so vocal with my feelings. That's ok. There are a thousand ways to express gratitude. Find what's most suitable for you & start expressing how much you love your friends.

I'm so lucky to have you

I'm so lucky to have you too big sis

You make life soo easy

You took the words right out of my mouth

You're the most amazing, fantastastic woman I know and you're only going to make things better in your life

I really love you

And I'm very grateful for you

4. Don't take rejection personally

As an adult who is actively trying to make new friends, I had to accept that out of the 7billion+ people in the world, I'm sure that at least a fraction of it would like me. I also know that not every connection is going to be lifelong. Sometimes, you will not receive the same efforts or reciprocation from the person you're trying to connect with. Learn to take rejections positively & keep an open mind about making new friends.

5. There is no right age to make friends

Losing friends is a very natural part of growing up. When something hurts that much, I just remind myself that I was lucky to have a friendship to miss in the first place (after the initial cursing & crying). I lost a lot of friends in my adolescence and met my closest friends in my adulthood.

At 27, I'm still meeting some of my favorite people just now. Don't beat yourself up if you haven't found your best friend(s) yet. Keep an open heart. Life is unpredictable...and maybe sometimes that's a good thing.

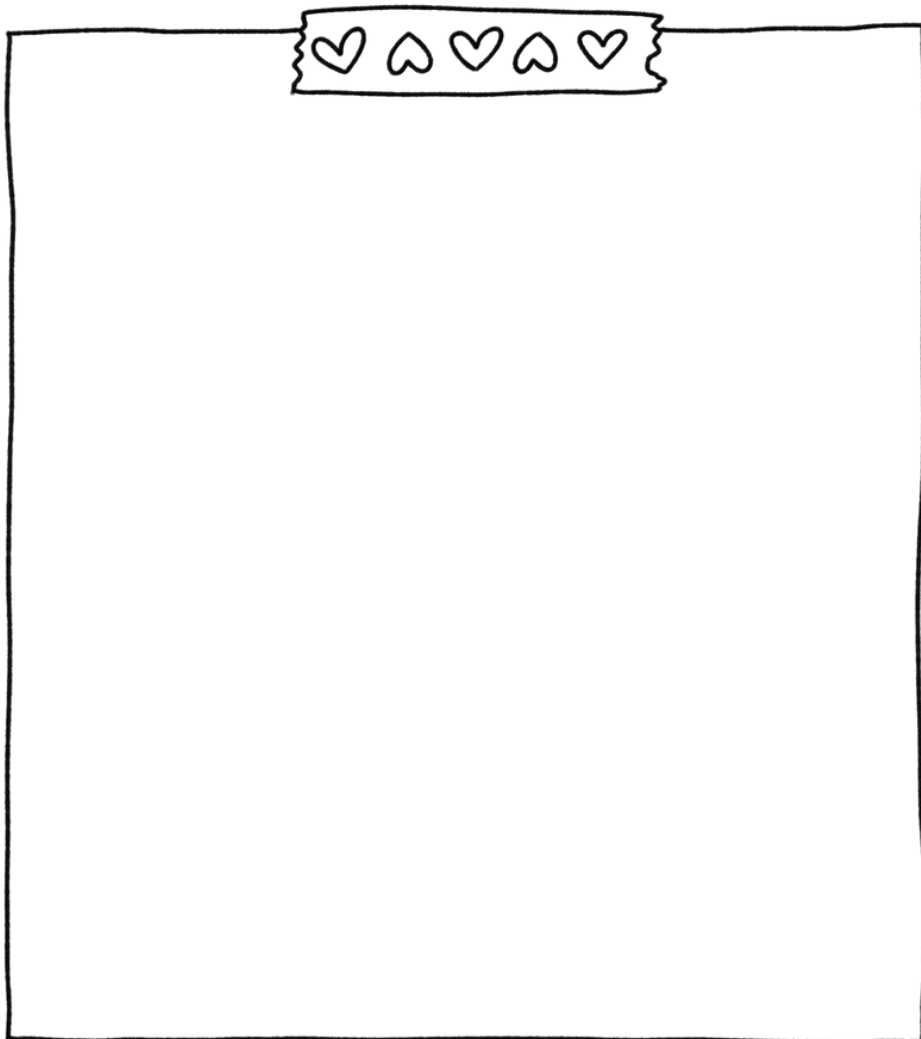
*Love,
Ushma*



Imagine this...

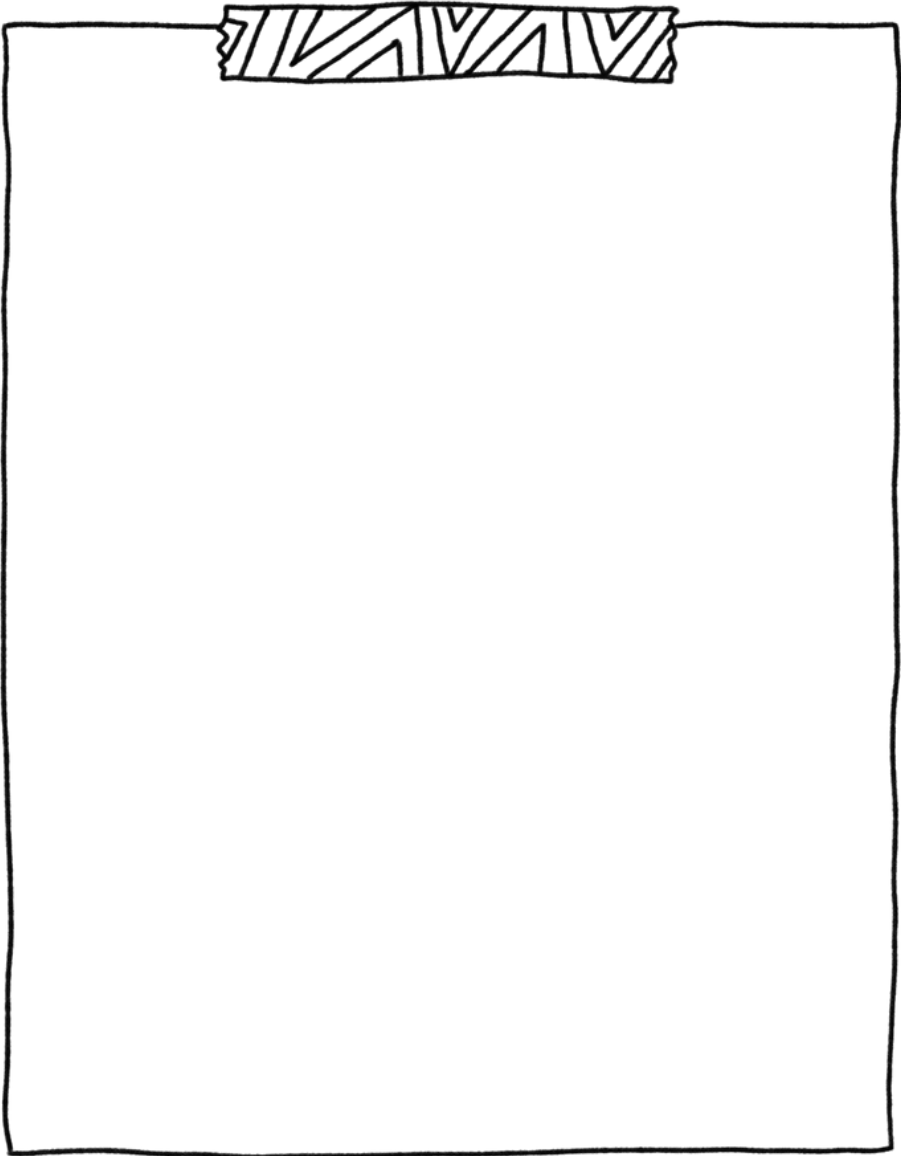
You're in a room full of people, who would you look for first?

- What makes this person so special?
- Who are some other people you would look for?
- What qualities make you want to look for them?



A large rectangular box with a hand-drawn border, intended for a drawing. At the top center of the box is a horizontal strip with a torn, ragged edge. Inside this strip are five simple line-drawn hearts arranged in a row.

Write a letter to a friend you lost ...



Reflect on your friendships

Gather photos of 10 important experiences you've had with your friends

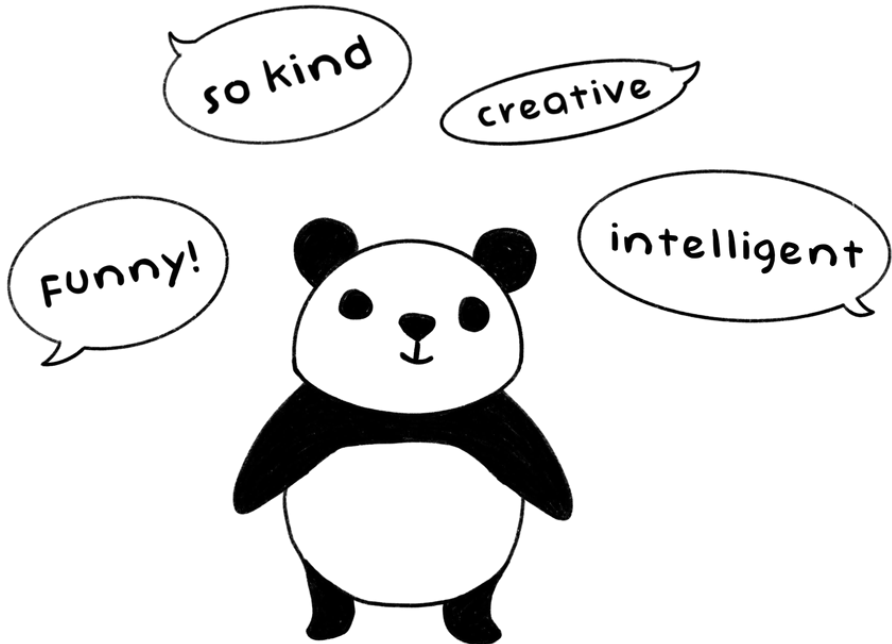
OR

Important experiences you would like to experience with friends (whether or not you've met your 'true friends' yet)

Find patterns

Find recurring patterns you've observed in your friendships ergo:

- 1.What's something that's common about ALL of your friends?
- 2.What is one word that ALL of your friends would use to describe you?
- 3.How does my relationship with my family influence my friendships?
- 4.What are some insecurities I observe myself having in ALL of my friendships?



Draw Your Friendship Garden

Visualize your friendships as a garden, with each flower representing a friend or a relationship. For example, a tall sunflower could represent someone who inspires you, while a small, delicate flower could symbolize a friend who brings you calm and peace.

Love Life

Word from a therapist

Your love life's D.O.A 🎵

Love is undoubtedly the most sought-after thing in the world.

We as human beings instinctively crave nothing more than connection, warmth, and a sense of belonging. Due to some traumatic experiences in my adolescence, I found it very difficult to date or to trust men. I enjoyed my innocent adolescent crushes here and there, but it never progressed beyond that.

In my early 20s, when I felt ready again, I just assumed that I would instantly meet the love of my life. I couldn't have been more wrong!

There was so much that has changed about dating since my last experience. There were a lot of warm, fuzzy feelings (Like I remembered) & they were often followed by heartbreaks (This, I didn't remember).

Losing love was tough but the idea of missing out on it was even tougher. So, I kept putting myself out there. Some of these connections turned into friendships. Some into short-lived intense romances; and others, well, they turned into stories.

Heartbreaks are insanely isolating. Yes, you may have people supporting you through it, but only you can actually feel the sharp pain that comes along with it. I struggled with self-esteem and felt hopeless. I compared myself to others who found it seemingly easier. But the one thing I never did was give up. I kept healing my broken heart over and over only to take another blow.

We often assume that if we go through enough bad experiences, we will be rewarded with something great.

My biggest advice to anyone on the same boat as my younger self:

The reward is the journey; the end goal is just the bonus.

Good luck!



Survival Guide

1. Misery loves company

Having a community of people you can talk to, get support from and possibly even relate to.

2. Know your needs

Knowing what I wanted and being assertive about it saved me from countless wasted hours and heartbreaks. Also, being unapologetic about the same helped me be less harsh with myself.

3. Have a life beyond

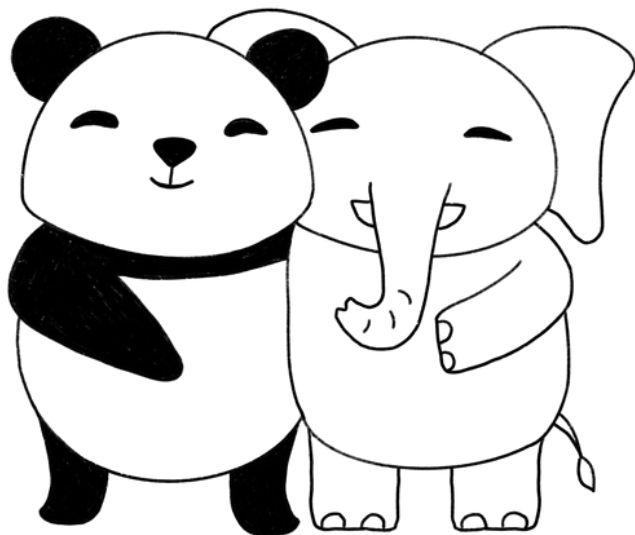
Having hobbies, dreams, and travel plans that were in alignment with my ideal life helped soften the blow of heartbreaks by a lot.

4. Allow grief

Losses are painful. Even the loss of a potential you saw in someone. Allow yourself to feel this pain. Cry it out, be loud about it. Rejoice, you're a person!

5. Go to therapy

Honestly, my therapist has changed my perspective about love and loss. It helped me unlearn some harmful ideas and allowed me to honor myself enough to know what I deserved.

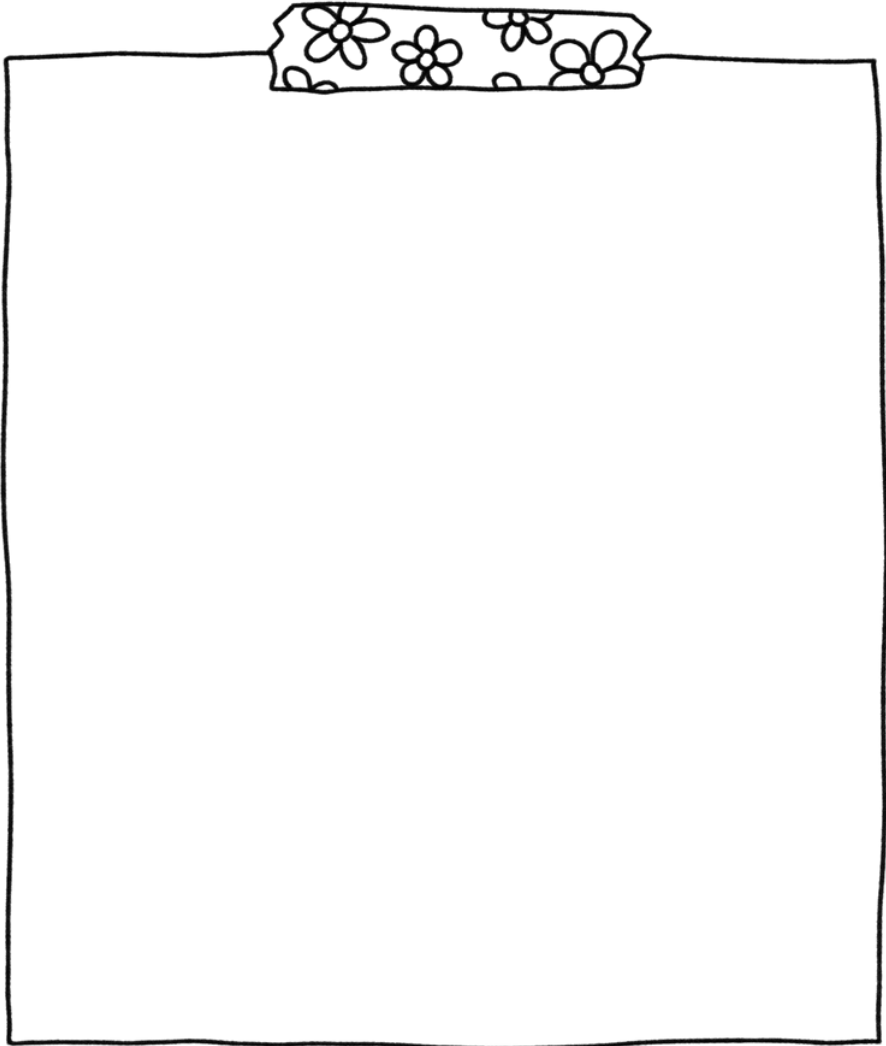


Love,
Ushma

Unfinished Business

Write a letter to someone in your past with whom you have 'Unfinished Business'

Unfinished Business is when you feel like there's some part of a relationship in the past that feels unresolved. Recognizing this helps us move on and get more clarity about what we want in our future relationships.



We all have flaws & insecurities.

What are yours?

Be honest with yourself & note/draw them here.

A large rectangular box with a hand-drawn, slightly irregular border, intended for a person to draw or write their flaws and insecurities. At the top center of the box is a horizontal decorative strip. This strip has a jagged, torn-paper-like edge and is filled with a pattern of small circles and five-pointed stars of varying sizes.

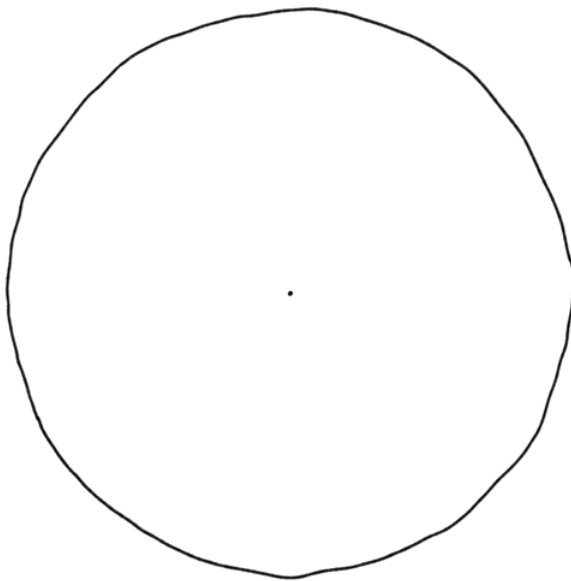
How can you learn to love/accept them?

The main areas of our lives are generally:

Love, Friendship, Health, Work, Family, Travel, Hobbies

How much of your mind is occupied with each?

TIP: Assign different colors to the areas of your life and slices the circle on the basis of how prominent that area is for you (e.g. biggest slice for career if that's the one you think about the most)



- ☐ Health
- ☐ Love
- ☐ Friendship
- ☐ Work
- ☐ Family
- ☐ Hobbies
- ☐ Travel

Dearest readers,

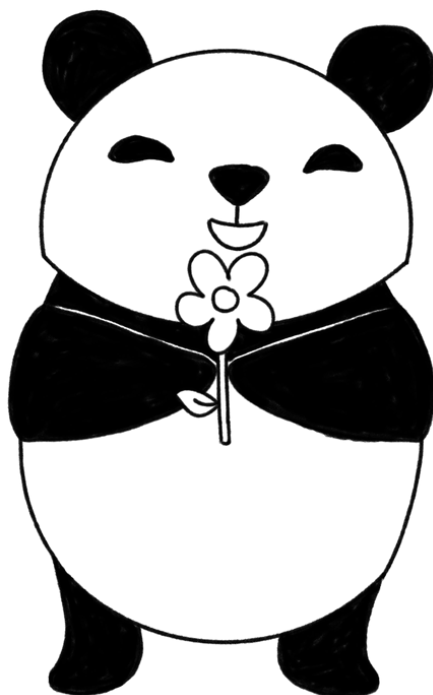
Chances are, that if you picked up this journal, you were either looking for some sense of peace, belonging, or a chance at a better relationship with yourself.

When we started writing this journal, coincidentally, I think we were looking for the same. The goal was to make mental health easily accessible and less threatening. We wanted to reach out to people beyond our existing clients.

Making this journal has been the most rewarding experience of our lives. We sincerely hope that this journey helped you ***Get Lost in the Right Direction.***

Lots of love & healing.

Ushma & Riddhi



This is not your typical journal!

Life can be really complex. Journaling does not need to be. Which is why we did our best to make this journal as much YOURS as it's OURS. Unlike a typical journal, you do not need to go in chronological order. If you look at the index, it will direct you to a page that aligns with how you are feeling.

When we started working on the journal, our main goal was to give you a companion- something to take around with you on days when you are feeling too much... or days when you are not sure how to talk to anyone... or even as a means to have deeper connections with the people around you.

The journal is black and white because, like we said before, this book is YOURS! The purpose of the illustrations is to provide you with a partially blank canvas. We encourage you to color every page, every illustration, and every thought into existence.

May this book provide you the much needed respite you deserve.

About Us

Riddhi Panchal & Ushma Asher are therapists with a master's degree in Clinical Psychology. They share a common love for travel, coffee, & mental health. This journal is their latest project in their 7-year long journey doing private practice & workshops.



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